VALUE CHAIN ANALYSIS

Product development opportunities for tourism









KINGDOM OF ESWATINI

International Trade Centre's Alliances for Action under the 'Eswatini: Promoting growth through competitive alliances project' funded by the European Union

International Trade Centre

ALLIANCES FOR ACTION

SIVINQABA



Mantenga Cultural Village ©John Hale

Executive summary

In the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic, **Eswatini's tourism sector has faced significant challenges** in its path to recovery. Though international arrivals have been recovering (210,705 in 2021, 502,541 in 2022, 842,441 in 2023), total leisure visitors remain low at around 200,000, with a reduced average length of stay from 4.03 days in 2021 to 2.63 days. Eswatini's struggle with **limited visibility, poor online reputation, and a lack of competitive advantage in key leisure markets** further exacerbates the problem.

In response, the Government of the Kingdom of Eswatini requested support from the International Trade Centre (ITC) to strengthen Eswatini's competitive advantage through identifying and selecting the most suitable and valuable segments of tourists for a targeted marketing focus. The aim is also to improve the impact of the tourism sector on local employment and income, particularly through cross-sectoral links with agriculture, crafts, etc. The initiative involves a tourism value chain analysis and an evaluation of Eswatini's perception as a tourism destination, focusing on its competitive position and the market's reception as well as online. To support this, the ITC commissioned independent experts, a tourism economist and a digital marketing specialist, to undertake desk and field research, as well as host participative in-person and online workshops to share findings and provide training.

The first step of ITC support included a literature review of existing policies and strategies related to tourism in the Kingdom of Eswatini and an evaluation of the effectiveness of the destination's digital presence. The second step focused on meetings with public and private tourism stakeholders, including business, enabling authorities, and associations in Eswatini. The third step consisted of the team engaging with tourism products and services in-country through five days of site visits. This visit, and the preliminary findings, were presented at an all-day workshop on February 20th, 2024. **Key findings underscore the necessity for a marketing strategy that emphasizes structuration, differentiation, and promotion to elevate Eswatini's tourism sector.**

Despite Eswatini's year-over-year recovery from the pandemic's impacts, the current visitor profile—primarily transit with minimal stay—signals an urgent need for redirection. To put it simply, **Eswatini is not attracting the right market segments**, even though international operators are interested in packages of 5 to 7 days or more. Today, although some operators can offer this type of product, it remains marginal in terms of the overall range of tourism products and services on offer. Generally speaking, **the current experience offered to visitors is rather passive**, with community tourism rarely immersive or creative in terms of experience. Also, the visitor's stay is not a journey within the destination, but rather a succession of independent stages. As a result, there is a drastic lack of themed offers organized on the basis of the destination's assets (gastronomy, culture, slow mobility possibilities, etc.). The structuration of tourism's offer requires the structuration of all the players involved.

The approach in this report is to align with the government's vision of making Eswatini *"a preferred tourism destination and a leader in sustainable tourism".* Therefore, it mostly **encourages the destination to target responsible tourists,** aiming to enhance the destination's image and pivot towards a performance-oriented overall approach including in terms of online presence. **The incorporation of digital monitoring training and workshops related to product development programs** will equip local stakeholders with new skills, supporting the job creation initiative and helping the long-term sustainability and competitiveness of Eswatini's tourism sector.

The opportunity to attract responsible tourist markets presents a window to reshape Eswatini's tourism future. By adopting a considered and strategic approach to marketing and product development, Eswatini can transition towards sustainable growth, attracting visitors who are not just passing through but are engaged, spending, and contributing to the local economy. **While Eswatini is unlikely to become the sole destination for a trip to Southern Africa in the short or medium term, it could be the destination that triggers a trip to the region.**

To conclude, **this report proposes a detailed action plan** to achieve these objectives. Certain activities are prioritized in order to rapidly increase the destination's discoverability online and the image it wishes to share. To achieve this, it will be necessary to simultaneously develop products and, more specifically, itineraries and content tailored to the new target audiences. Eswatini has the ability to differentiate itself and satisfy the imagination of international visitors while offering a deeper experience that will greatly benefit the creation of jobs and income in local communities.

End of Executive Summary

Introduction

Country profile

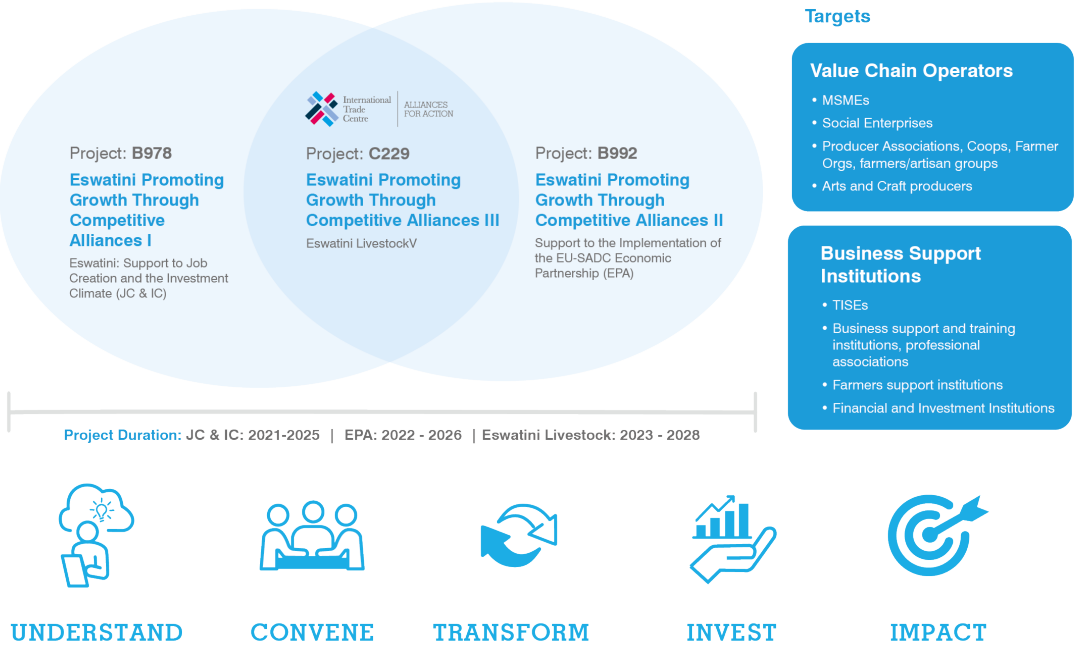
Eswatini is a small landlocked country of 17,364 km² with a population of 1.2 million and a population density of 63 people/km². Despite its small size, it contains four agro-ecological zones. It shares borders with South Africa and Mozambique. Although classified as a lower-middle income country, 59% of Eswatini's population lived below the poverty line in 2017. The country is characterized by high levels of poverty and inequality. Eswatini is ranked 112/190 in the Doing Business rankings, and the country still has a high level of poverty (63%), with significant income inequalities and an unemployment rate of 41%.

Eswatini is the fourth largest sugar producer in Africa and sugar production accounts for more than half of the country's agricultural output, contributing some $285 million, or a total of 16% of GDP[1]. However, the fall in sugar prices, associated to the drop in customs revenues collected under the SACU (Southern African Custom Union) and the accumulation of arrears to the private sector have led to a fall in economic growth (+2% in 2018). In addition, there is also a large forestry sector growing pine and eucalyptus. The sector has a competitive bioregional advantage in that pine plantations mature in 16 years, compared with 40 years in the northern hemisphere[2].

The European Union is one of Eswatini's main donors, after the African Development Bank, with EUR 62 million for the 11th European Development Fund (EDF) (2014-2020), which focuses on health, agriculture and food security. Eswatini ratified the EU-SADC Economic Partnership Agreement (EPA) in August 2016. Eswatini is indeed a member of SADC (Southern African Development Community) and the Commonwealth. Eswatini was one of the first countries to ratify the Paris Climate Agreement in autumn 2016. Eswatini is also the last African state to recognize Taiwan, which has made some high-profile investments in the country (roads, new international airport).

ITC in the Kingdom of Eswatini

The International Trade Centre (ITC) is implementing the European Union (EU) funded programme ''Support to the Implementation of the EU-SADC Economic Partnership Agreement (EPA) – Kingdom of Eswatini" (2022-2026), the "Support to Job Creation and the Investment Climate project" (JC&IC), (2021-2025) and the "Support to Eswatini Livestock Value Chain Development Programme" (2023-2027) The programme is the result of a co-creation process between the Government of Eswatini, EU and ITC as illustrated below:

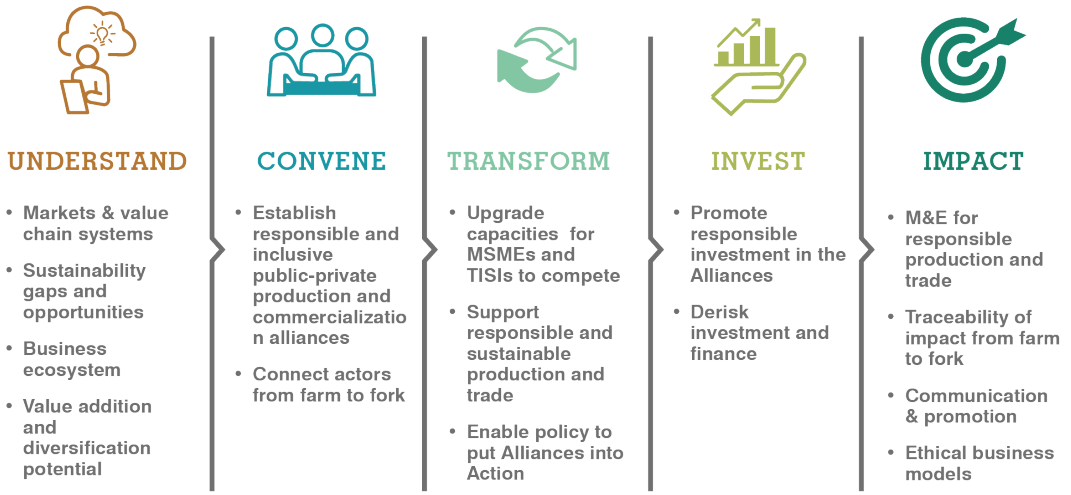


1 Mtasebula, M. 2020. "Sweetening the deal – How the Eswatini sugar industry is helping keep the country's economy afloat amidst global uncertainties." African leadership magazine, accessed 20 January. https://www.africanleadershipmagazine.co.uk/sweetening-the-deal-how-the-eswatini-sugar-industry-is-helping-keep-the-countrys-economy-afloat-amidst-global-uncertainties/.

2 New Agriculturalist. 2002. "Country profile – Swaziland." New Agriculturalist, accessed 20 January. http://www.new-ag.info/en/country/profile.php?a=863.

The Programme responds to the Government's development priorities and focuses on generating a private sector-led export drive, with implementation relying on the "Alliances for Action (A4A)" approach developed by the ITC as the implementing agency of the programme.

The Alliances for Action (A4A) is an inclusive, participatory multi-stakeholder consultative and validated approach aiming to achieve sustained competitiveness and value creation aligned to market needs, resulting in shared prosperity and job creation. Its foundation is built upon a public-private partnership of mutual trust and has five pillars in its formulation and implementation, namely: Understand, Convene, Transform, Invest, and Impact (see figure below, which explains the A4A approach in detail).



The implementation of the interventions focuses on promoting sustainable business models, production and market systems whilst ensuring partnerships between the different stakeholders in the value chain. As a result, the product-market combination is reinforced for high-value/niche products and services, the profit of the companies is increased, and decent jobs are created, ensuring at the same time environmental protection. The various value chain stakeholders, including lead firms and support institutions work together and form market-led partnerships that enhance value chain integration, technical support, policy alignment and local institutional capacity building.

Acknowledgements

The goal of this report is to provide practical steps to strengthen the competitive advantage of Eswatini's tourism sector.

The International Trade Centre (ITC) expresses its deepest gratitude to the Ministry of Tourism and Environmental Affairs, to the Eswatini Tourism Authority (ETA), the ETA Marketing and Product Development Board of Directors committee members, and representatives of the Eswatini tourism industry who shared their knowledge and experiences of the tourism value chain in Eswatini.

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Acronyms

A4A	Alliances for Action
BCG	Boston Consulting Group
CAR	Competitive Advantage Ratio
CSR	Corporate Social Responsibility
DEU	Germany
DMO	Destination Management Organization
EDF	European Development Fund
EMA	Environment Management Act
ENTC	Eswatini National Trust Commission
EPA	Economic Partnership Agreement
ESG	Environmental, Social, and Governance
ETA	Eswatini Tourism Authority
FPA	Flora Protection Act
FRA	France
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
GSTC	Global Sustainable Tourism Council
HOATES	Hospitality and Tourism Association of Eswatini
ICT	Information and Communications Technology
ITC	International Trade Centre
JC&IC	Job Creation and Investment Climate project
MICE	Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, Exhibitions
MOTEA	Ministry of Tourism and Environmental Affairs
MOZ	Mozambique
MSME	Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprise
NED	Netherlands
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
NLP	Natural language processing
NRA	Natural Resources Act
NTCA	National Trust Commission Act
PFA	Private Forests Act
RSA	South Africa
RTA	Responsible Tourism Adviser
SACU	Southern African Custom Union
SADC	Southern African Development Community
SAO	Swazi Administration Order
SEO	Search Engine Optimization
SMH	Small and Medium Hotels
SSAA	Safeguarding of Swazi Areas Act
TFCA	Transfrontier Conservation Areas
TTCI	Travel and Tourism Competitiveness Index
UNESCO-MAB	United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization Man and the Biosphere Programme
USP	Unique Selling Proposition
WBPA	Wild Birds Protect Act
WEF	World Economic Forum

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PURPOSE AND STRUCTURE OF THE STUDY

TIMEFRAME AND OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY 2
METHODOLOGY AND LIMITATIONS 3

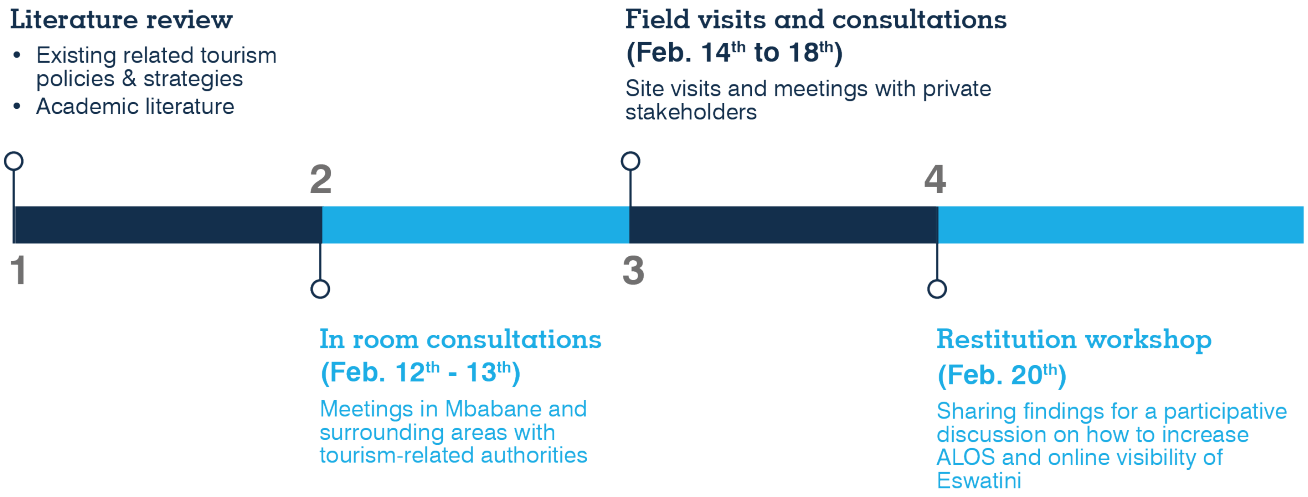
PURPOSE AND STRUCTURE OF THE STUDY

Timeframe and objectives of the study

The project is based on the request of the Government of the Kingdom of Eswatini to strengthen Eswatini's competitive advantage through identifying and selecting the most suitable and valuable segments of tourists for a targeted marketing focus. This request includes support in undertaking market segmentation for Eswatini's main tourism source markets, including assistance developing a market overview, travel patterns, channels, competitors, target segment, and potential markets.

The intervention is based on the fact that Eswatini has limited international visibility, resulting in poor performance in terms of leisure visitor arrivals and a low average length of stay. This is mainly the result of large numbers of transit visitors or simply weekend residents from South Africa or Mozambique taking advantage of the safety of the destination.

Figure 1 - Timeframe of the study



The study took place during February 2024 and comprised four main phases described in the section below. The objectives of the study were to gather sufficient information to respond to the Eswatini Tourism Authority's request to improve Eswatini's competitiveness as a tourism destination. Overall, the study consisted in:

- Evaluating how Eswatini's tourism is perceived globally - going beyond understanding the market to also include the market's perception of Eswatini (reputation).
- Analyzing Eswatini's competitiveness by indicating its strengths and weaknesses in delivering products and services able to attract the targeted markets (i.e. the three groups of travelers)
- Identifying opportunities for revenue and job creation (especially through packaging and structuration of stakeholders)
- Formulating sound recommendations and building capacities to enable Eswatini Tourism Authority and the private sector to increase their businesses by strengthening Eswatini's competitive advantage.

Methodology and limitations

Overall study methodology

A team of two consultants (an economist and a digital marketing specialist) worked under the direct supervision of the ITC-HQ based A4A Associate Programme officer and under overall supervision of Eswatini Project Manager, in close coordination with National Project Operations Manager. A strong support was also provided by the Eswatini Tourism Authority to undertake the in-country duties.

The methodology consisted in four main interrelated phases starting with a literature review of existing policies and strategies related to tourism in the Kingdom of Eswatini and an evaluation of the effectiveness of the destination's digital presence (step one). This exercise enabled us to compare the destination's objectives, in terms of its vision for the sector, with the resources deployed to achieve them and the results obtained, both quantitative (growth, market share) and qualitative (perception of the destination, satisfaction, etc.).

With this initial perspective in mind, the second step was to listen to the main public and private stakeholders. As tourism is a cross-cutting sector, meetings were held with the various authorities and enabling institutions responsible for supporting the sector and tourism-related businesses at both municipality and national levels (a list is available in annex). In addition, meetings were held with representatives of the private sector (HOATES) and a number of inbound operators to gain a better understanding of how the market works and the different visitor segments.

The third step consisted of understanding the range of tourism products and services on offer throughout the country (see map), while meeting the various types of players involved. Over a period of five days, the team was able to visit a large number of private and community structures, including the main tourist sites, without, however, taking part in the activities on offer (detailed itinerary in annex).

Figure 2 – Field Study Itinerary



Source: Authors using Google Maps

The final step was to share the preliminary findings with the Eswatini Tourism Authority before organizing and facilitating

a workshop to highlight the opportunities that may exist for Eswatini through better stakeholder structuring, strong differentiation of the destination from its competitors and improved promotion through the use of digital marketing. With this in mind, activities were organized to help participants understand that Eswatini has sufficient resources for international visitors to stay longer, provided they are presented in the right way. In particular, the issue of differentiating the destination on the basis of geographical criteria (scenic points, untouched scenery, etc.), thematic criteria (gastronomy, community tourism, slow mobility, etc.), and other criteria was raised.

To do this, participants were first invited to put together multi-day tourist tours based on themes chosen during an initial exercise on the destination's USPs. After a brief presentation of the sustainability criteria for tourism products, they were invited to make their packages more responsible. This was followed by a presentation of the performance of the destination's website and existing tools for improving visibility and performance. The workshop ended with an exercise to prepare the promotional stages for each circuit.

Limitations - Although this study attempts to provide a comprehensive analysis of the tourism situation in Eswatini, and despite the small size of the destination, it was not possible to visit rural communities or spend more time at sites of interest. The involvement of local communities in the tourism sector was poorly understood and only community-run accommodations were visited, which did not allow an assessment of the quality of experiences that communities can offer to international visitors. However, interviews with tourism operators show that most of the interaction between visitors and guests takes the form of support for orphanages and schools.

Another major limitation of this study, and of all those conducted after COVID, is the impact of the pandemic on national and international tourism trends and statistics. As far as possible, the study takes into account pre-COVID dynamics and more recent results with the necessary hindsight to exploit these data.

Methodology for a portfolio analysis management model

A portfolio management model is intended to help destinations seeking to improve returns from their visitors but also to achieve their outcomes. Key components work together to create a robust structure. In this report we have chosen a three-step approach that includes market segment selection, diversification strategies, and performance benchmarks. This is designed to leverage destination data, be modifiable, and be reproducible by the local team without the need for further interventions.

(i) Market segment selection

Choosing the right market segments is foundational. **Destinations must consider their goals to pick the best mix.** Market segments typically include short, mid and long-haul visitors and all have different expectations, levels of expenditures, or length of stay. As much as possible, use up-to-date information (e.g. exit surveys, recent statistics, visitor feedback) as market segments will evolve with time. With more current information, more precision is possible allowing for better informed strategies.

How to proceed?

1. **Identify source countries** - Start with short-haul regional neighbors and important long-haul markets

2. **Filter by demographics** - Depending on available data, categorize by:

    a. Visit reason
    b. Length of stay
    c. Level of expenditure
    d. Age
    e. Group size
    f. Other (types of activities, perceptions/comments, etc.)

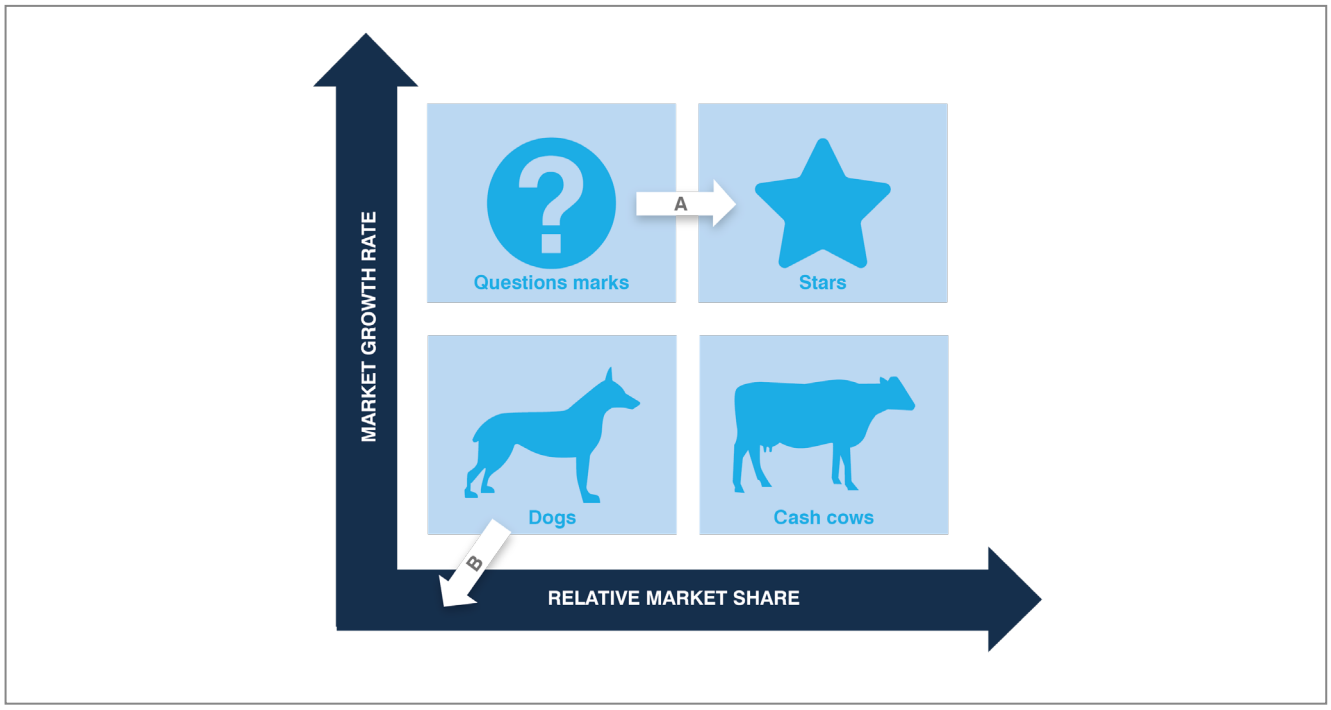
3. **Analyze according to objectives** - Combine demographic details to find strong subsegments (ie. segments

that outperform selected goals) within each source country.

(ii) Diversification strategies

Diversification reduces risk by spreading investments across various market segments. **It involves more than just market mix**— geographical spread and preferences/trends matter too. Using a **diverse strategic approach** helps mitigate the markets that do not benefit a lot to the destination but could be more stable over the years.

Figure 3 – BCG Product Portfolio Matrix



Source: Corporate Finance Institute

Following the outline of our portfolio management model, it's pertinent to reference and adapt the Boston Consulting Group (BCG) Matrix, a renowned business tool, to the context of tourism management. This model categorizes products or services into four quadrants based on their market growth rate and market share, namely Stars, Cash Cows, Question Marks, and Dogs. Here's how the BCG Matrix can be adapted to tourism:

- **Stars (High Growth, High Market Share):** These are the booming segments or attractions. They are popular, bring in a lot of visitors, and have the potential for further growth. Investment in these areas should be prioritized to maintain their status and ensure they continue to thrive.
- **Cash Cows (Low Growth, High Market Share):** These represent well-established segments with a steady flow of tourists but limited growth potential. The strategy here involves maintaining these segments efficiently while maximizing profit without significant new investments.
- **Question Marks (High Growth, Low Market Share):** These are emerging segments with growth potential but currently hold a small share of the market. Strategic decisions need to be made about whether to invest in these areas to turn them into Stars or to divest if the potential return does not justify the investment.
- **Dogs (Low Growth, Low Market Share):** These segments are the underperformers with little to no growth prospects. The recommendation could be to divest or repurpose these resources into more promising areas.

As a way to adapt the matrix for a more nuanced analysis within the tourism and travel industry, growth and market share, the traditional axes of the BCG Matrix can be replaced with scaled growth rate by country (x-axis) and scaled difference in length of stay (y-axis). By scaling the growth rate by country, this adaptation retains the original intent of assessing growth potential but does so on a country-by-country basis. This is particularly relevant in industries like tourism, where the attractiveness and potential of destinations can vary significantly.

The scaled difference in length of stay serves as a proxy for the concept of market share, reflecting the relative attractiveness or value of different tourist segments based on their engagement (measured by the length of stay). Longer stays typically indicate higher tourist engagement, more spending, and potentially greater loyalty. By scaling this difference, the matrix highlights segments that not only contribute to immediate revenue but also possess high engagement potential, suggesting opportunities for creating more tailored and effective marketing strategies.

This adaptation of the BCG Matrix axes aligns with the unique characteristics and data insights relevant to the tourism industry. It allows for **a more nuanced analysis by combining macro-level insights (country growth rates) with micro-level behaviors (tourist engagement through length of stay)**. This approach can uncover strategic segments that may not be immediately apparent through traditional analysis, offering a competitive advantage in market positioning, resource allocation, and strategy development. It suggests that **growth opportunities are not merely about attracting more tourists but also about enhancing the quality and depth of their engagement**. This strategic pivot can guide businesses toward sustainable growth strategies, leveraging both market expansion and customer-centric approaches for long-term success.

How to proceed?

1. **Evaluate Market Segment**

    a. Classify each segment according to the categories (Stars, Cash Cows, Question Marks, Dogs) based on their positioning in a matrix from combining their country's growth rate (scaled in comparison with other countries) and their segment's length of stay (scaled in comparison with other segments).

2. **Stay The Course: For Stars and Cash Cows**

    a. **Stars:** Focus on maintaining or increasing investment to capitalize on growth opportunities. Innovate product offerings and enhance marketing strategies to secure their leading position.

    b. **Cash Cows:** Optimize these segments for profitability. They require less investment but should be managed to continue generating steady revenue. Look for cost-efficient ways to maintain their appeal without significant new investments.

3. **Diversify and Innovate: For Question Marks**

    a. Conduct a deeper analysis to understand the growth potential of Question Marks. This involves looking at emerging trends, visitor feedback, and tour operator outreach.

    b. Decide whether to invest resources to grow these segments into Stars. This may include targeted marketing campaigns, product development, and partnerships with tour operators seeking new destinations.

4. **Reassess or Repurpose: For Dogs**

    a. Determine if these segments align with any strategic objectives or if they can be revitalized through innovation or rebranding.

    b. Consider withdrawing from segments that consistently underperform and reallocating resources to more promising areas.

5. **Implement Tailored Strategies**

    a. **For Stars and Cash Cows:** Implement strategies aimed at expansion or efficient maintenance. This could include enhancing existing attractions or services and improving infrastructure to accommodate growth.
    b. For Question Marks: Trial innovative marketing mixes and product offerings. Use data analytics to monitor their performance closely, ready to pivot based on their evolution.
    c. For Dogs: Develop exit strategies or transformation plans. This could involve phasing out certain offerings or completely revamping them based on market research.

6. **Monitoring and Adjustment**

    a. Continuously monitor the performance of each segment against set benchmarks and the overall strategic goals.
    b. Be prepared to adjust strategies based on evolving market conditions, visitor preferences, and the performance of each segment. This dynamic approach ensures resources are allocated efficiently to maximize returns.

(iii) Performance benchmarks

Performance benchmarks **track progress against goals** and help to compare portfolio results. Destinations select relevant indexes that reflect their **marketing strategy and market segments.** Regularly **assessing against benchmarks** provides insights for adjustments.

How to proceed?

1. **Select indicators -** Choose ones that align with your strategic objectives, including visitor numbers, average length of stay, visitor satisfaction, and total tourist expenditure or expenditures per day.
2. **Collect data -** Use a variety of sources such as visitor surveys, tourism receipts, website analytics to measure against benchmarks.
3. **Adjust strategies -** Identify successful tactics to amplify and areas where adjustments are needed.
4. **Communicate and update -** Share results with stakeholders, including tourism businesses, local communities, and government agencies.

Limitations of portfolio management model

One of the key limitations to the portfolio management model is data availability and quality. Reliable and up-to-date data on market segments, visitor behavior, and preferences may be difficult to obtain, especially for emerging markets or niche segments. Inconsistent or low-quality data can lead to inaccurate analysis and decision-making. This limitation underscores the importance of a collaborative approach between tourism managers and data analysts, as advocated by Dolnicar and Leisch (2010).

Another is resource constraints. Though designed to be accessible and repeatable, maintaining a portfolio management model requires significant resources, including personnel for data analysis, marketing, and strategy development. Smaller destinations or those with limited budgets may struggle to allocate sufficient resources.

Adjusting to market changes
The travel market can shift quickly, including changes in global travel trends (e.g. the growth of bleisure travel), consumer preferences (e.g. an embrace of slow mobility or increasing *"flight shaming"* for some markets), and competitive landscapes. In order for this model to stay useful, some of the following adjustments may need to be made:

Adhering to regulatory requirements
Changes in source markets can have a ripple effect in-country. As an example, a new supply chain law is entering into effect in 2027 in the European Union that says large companies can be fined if their supply chains are found to employ forced or child labour or are damaging the environment (e.g. deforestation). Destinations will need to prepare their tourism stakeholders on how to be transparent in their operations.

Dealing with market volatility
Even the best run model cannot account for all the variables that can lead to fluctuation in a source market. Destinations are encouraged to be proactive with diversifying their marketing mix.

Incorporating ESG factors
Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) considerations are becoming increasingly important to travelers and to

international tour operators as well (e.g. EU supply chain act). Destinations that prioritize sustainability and ethical practices can attract a growing segment of responsible tourists. The below are examples of how ESG can begin to be implemented.

Table 1 – ESG considerations in tourism

ESG Aspects	Action Steps
Environmental	▪ **Spotlight on Carbon Neutrality -** Integrate the goal of achieving carbon neutrality into tourism operations. ▪ **Reduce Waste Through Norm Changes -** Address the transient, wasteful nature of the hospitality industry by normalizing 'green choices' for consumers, such as reusing towels and reducing single-use items. ▪ **Collaborative Sustainability Efforts -** Promote activities that contribute to the conservation of natural habitats and promote carbon offsetting for travelers.
Social	▪ **Diversity and Inclusion Initiatives -** Amplify diversity and inclusion efforts in the hospitality sector, focusing on both visible characteristics like gender and race, and invisible factors such as intellectual abilities and mental health. ▪ **Employee Well-Being and Rights -** Address long-hours, low-wage culture by caring for employees' health, safety, and well-being, utilizing natural materials and fostering a safe work environment. Support human rights and youth employment programs to build a more equitable future for low-skilled labor and vulnerable youth populations. ▪ **Cultural Respect and Community Support -** Continue to develop tourism experiences that respect and celebrate local cultures authentically, while ensuring tangible benefits to local communities through job creation, skills development, and support for local businesses.
Governance	▪ **Ethics and Transparency -** Embrace ethical business practices and transparency as core to governance, including fair pricing, honest marketing, and the responsible management of tourist data. ▪ **Effective Stakeholder Engagement -** Establish mechanisms for effective stakeholder engagement, incorporating local communities, industry partners, and tourists in decision-making, an important step for balancing global brand standards with respect for local customs and regulations. ▪ **Compliance and Reporting -** Ensure full compliance with local and international regulations affecting the tourism sector. Implement regular reporting on sustainability efforts and achievements to maintain accountability and foster trust among stakeholders, emphasizing the company's ethical stance and commitment to sustainability.

Source: adapted from EHL Hospitality Business School.

Challenges and Solutions

Destinations face a variety of challenges that can impede their ability to effectively monitor, adapt, and grow. The following table outlines some of the challenges encountered in this process with solutions that can help overcome obstacles in implementing the results from the portfolio management model.

Table 2 – Solutions to accompany market portfolio management

Challenges	Solutions
Too many projects for limited resources available/ ineffective project prioritization	Establish a structured evaluation process for new tourism projects or initiatives. This process would entail clear stages or checkpoints at which projects are assessed for their potential impact, feasibility, and alignment with the strategy, ensuring only promising projects proceed, thereby optimizing resource allocation.
Go/Kill decisions made in the absence of solid information	Create a resource inventory for Eswatini's tourism sector, including available budgets, skilled personnel, infrastructure limits, and environmental carrying capacity. Use this inventory to assess each project's feasibility and ensure that the portfolio does not exceed the destination's capacity to deliver quality experiences.
Too many minor projects in the portfolio	Use portfolio management tools to regularly review the mix of projects in terms of risk, potential return, strategic alignment, and resource requirements. This can be achieved by adopting one of the two approaches—either a financial perspective focused on expected returns or a strategic perspective focused on alignment with long-term goals.

Source: adapted from Cooper et al (2000)

By acknowledging the limitations inherent in data collection, the need for reactivity in the face of market fluctuations, and the importance of finding a balance between immediate needs and long-term aspirations, destinations are better equipped to respond to short-term challenges while also proactively shaping their future, ensuring resilience, competitiveness, and sustainability for years to come.

2

TOURISM DEVELOPMENT IN THE KINGDOM OF ESWATINI

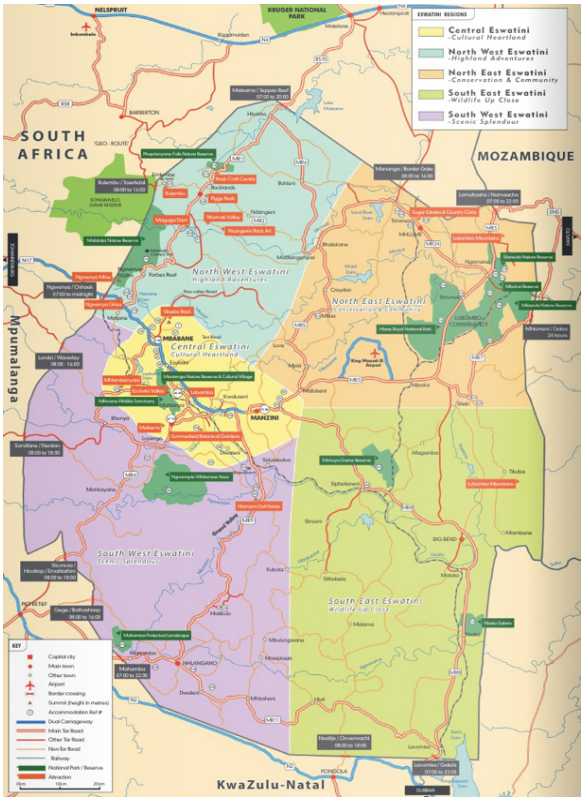
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TOURISM DEVELOPMENT IN THE KINGDOM OF ESWATINI

Key tourism resources and attractions

In the *"Product development strategy and Product Development toolkit"* report (2013), it is considered that the Kingdom of Eswatini has a limited array of unique selling propositions (USPs). Three key USPs are the Sibebe Rock, Ngwenya Mine and the Royal Events. However, the same report highlights that the destination counts a number of special selling propositions such as annual events (e.g. MTN Bushfire, Simunye Country Club Annual Fair), several nature reserves with private facilities (Mlawula Nature Reserve, Malolotja Nature Reserve, Hlane Royal National Park/Mkhaya Game Reserve), Unusual quality handicrafts (Swazi candles (distinctive products); Ngwenya Glass Factory (figurines, vases and tableware all made from recycled glass); Malendela craft village), Nsangwini painted rocks and two world-class 18-hole golf courses.

Figure 4 – Location of tourism assets



Source: ETA Eswatini brochure 2020

Eswatini is relatively rich in biodiversity with an inordinately large plant and animal diversity. 12 endemic plants and a single endemic reptile are known to occur in the country. In total, the Kingdom of Eswatini has one national park (Hlane Royal National Park), 10 national reserves (Malolotja Nature Reserve, Mlilwane Wildlife Sanctuary, Mlawula Nature Reserve, Emantini, Libhetse, Mantenga Nature Reserve, Mkhaya Game Reserve, Phophonyane, Lubuyane and Lomati), three Ramsar Sites, wetlands of international importance (Hawane Nature Reserve and Dam, Sand Driver Dam, and Van Eck Dam) and one UNESCO-MAB biosphere reserve (Lubombo)[3].

The governance of these key natural resources fails into 5 different types as described in the below table.

3 UNEP-WCMC (2024). Protected Area Profile for Eswatini, the Kingdom of from the World Database on Protected Areas, February 2024. Available at: www.protectedplanet.net

Table 3 – Governance types of natural resources in Eswatini

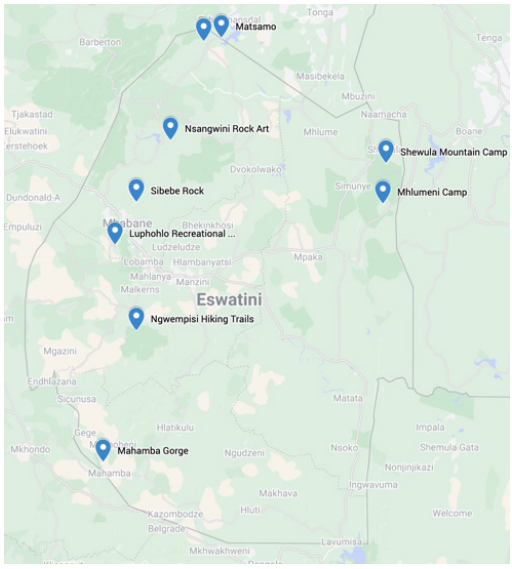
Governance types	Natural resources
Individual landowners	▪ Emantini, Libhetse, Phophonyane, Lubuyane, Lomati, Wide Horizon, Mhlosinga and Dombeya
Federal or national ministry or agency	▪ Mantenga Nature Reserve and Cultural Village ▪ Malolotja Nature Reserve ▪ Hawane Dam Reserve ▪ Mlawula Nature Reserve
Joint governance	▪ Hlane Royal National Park ▪ Lubombo Biosphere Reserve
Non-profit organizations	▪ Mlilwane Wildlife Sanctuary ▪ Mkhaya Game Reserve
For-profit organizations	▪ Sand River Dam ▪ Van Eck Dam ▪ Royal Jozini Private Game Reserve

Source: ETA database

Other famous attractions are related to the crafts industry as mentioned. In fact, three food and retail outlets have sprung up around three major players in Eswatini tourism: Swazi Candle, Ngwenya Glass Factory and the Bushfire festival.

There are a number of community camps all over the country. The Eswatini Tourism Authority is connected with seven community tourism products (Mahamba Gorge, Luphohlo Recreational Park, Ngwempisi Hiking Trails, Nsangwini Rock Art, Sibebe, Matsamo, Mvembili Botanical Gardens). In addition to the community camps developed for tourism visits, there are a number of artisan groups that contribute crafts to local producer Gone Rural (see map below). While these communities may not have current tourism products, they are both connected with the tourism value chain and their partner organizations expressed interest in being included in community-based tourism development. Additional community projects are being funded by the ENTC (e.g. Emaphophomeni waterfalls in the Tikhuba Community and potential community camp), as well as the community-owned and run Mhlumeni Bush Camp.

Figure 5 – Location of community camps and artisan groups

Community Camps & Products	Gone Rural Artisan Groups
	

Source: Made by authors from ETA and Gone Rural's information

Tourism statistics

This section is only a broad presentation of the tourism statistics for the Kingdom of Eswatini. A market segmentation approach is proposed in section 6.1. As previously mentioned, tourism statistics were severely disrupted by the COVID pandemic (see annex 2 for detailed tables and graphics). While an overall growth in arrivals can be observed before and after COVID, it does not concern all market segments. The European market, which represents the bulk of the leisure segment (55,1% in 2023), had been in continuous decline since 2017. However, we are seeing a recovery in this segment, with a market share similar to 2019 but still 2% below its best level (2017).

Table 4 – International visitors' arrivals to Eswatini (2015-2023)

Statistics	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023
Total	1,255,901	1,278,587	1,342,641	1,277,253	1,225,520	345,348	210,705	502,541	842,441
Incremental		22,686	64,054	-65,388	-51,733	-880,172	-134,643	291,836	339,900
%		1.81%	5.01%	-4.87%	-4.05%	-71.82%	-38.99%	138.50%	67.64%

Source: ETA database

Today, the main problem for the Kingdom of Eswatini is the low length of stay of its visitors (2.1 nights with transit visitors and 2.5 nights without using ETA data from 2023). The average value is skewed as much by transit visitors as by those coming for educational purposes (40.8 nights on average). For leisure visitors, the average length of stay is 1.8 nights. This low length of stay is explained by the high volume of visitors in direct transit or spending only one night in the country (48.76%). On the other hand, the second largest segment is that of visitors staying only between two and three nights in the country (41.70%). Today's tourism statistics are mainly driven by a consideration of the destination as an additional or 'bonus' to a stay in South Africa.

This is confirmed by the high number of visitors using their own vehicle or renting a car (83.4%) to cross the Kingdom of Eswatini. Air arrivals are rather limited (7-8%) with only two airlines serving the destination with Embraer jets with a maximum capacity of 50 seats. Leisure visitors account for less than 12% of arrivals by air. Major entry points (Ngwenya - 35.5%, Lavumisa 21.1%, Lamoyasha 14.9%, Matsamo 10.7%) reflect tourism paths from/to South Africa or Mozambique especially for the leisure visitors.

It is interesting to note that international visitor arrivals to Eswatini are highly seasonal, but above all that it has not succeeded in attracting the high-yield markets of Europe and North America during their winter season, unlike its neighbor South Africa, which sees a peak in international visitors during the Christmas holidays. While the absence of coastal areas in Eswatini, given the interest in beach destinations during this period, is an explanatory factor, the fact remains that the destination has not yet succeeded in capitalizing on this opportunity and attracting some of these flows.

Tourism economics in the Kingdom of Eswatini

According to Eswatini Central Bank, the services sector recorded a growth of 11.1 per cent, year-on-year, in the third quarter of 2023 from 10.9 per cent in the previous quarter and accounted for 5.7 percentage points in the overall GDP growth. The resilient growth was largely backed by the 'information & communication', 'wholesale & retail', 'public administration' as well as 'tourism related activities' subsectors. Tourism related activities remained on a positive recovery path with the number of tourist arrivals for the nine (9) months to September 2023 rising by 90.0 per cent compared to the same period the previous year. Tourism related activities output recorded a growth of 29.4 per cent in the third quarter of 2023 from 34.1 per cent in the previous quarter.

During the month of January 2024, the Rand/Lilangeni exchange rate weakened against the major trading currencies. The domestic unit depreciated by 0.8 per cent to record a monthly average of E18.80 against the US Dollar. This makes Eswatini's exports less expensive internationally, which in turn makes tourism in Eswatini more attractive.

In 2019, the benchmark year internationally due to the COVID pandemic, the contribution of travel and tourism to GDP for Eswatini was 4.8%. In 2022, the economic impact of tourism on GDP was around US $26 million (about one third of 2019). The contribution of travel and tourism to employment for Eswatini was 17.3 thousand persons in 2019 against 13.4 thousand in 2022. Though Eswatini contribution of travel and tourism to employment fluctuated substantially in recent years, it tended

to increase through the 2000 - 2019 period. However, Eswatini contribution of travel and tourism to employment growth tended to decrease through the 2000 - 2019 period ending at 6.4 % in 2019.

With 53,8% of the overall visitors' expenditures, the accommodation sector has the greatest impact on the economy. This is mostly due to the limited average length of stay of visitors and the low use of local transport. Most visitors are in transit, use their own car, or a hire car. The second biggest item of expenditure for visitors is food (40.6%) far ahead of spending on entertainment and others such as crafts.

Table 5 – Share of visitors' expenditures in Eswatini

Accommodation	Restaurant	Transport	Entertainment / other
53,8%	40,6%	0,2%	5,3%

Source: ETA database

An analysis of the tourism value chain is provided later in this document, including an overview of the volume and range of operators in the accommodation sector. However, no data were available concerning the benefits from the commercial exploitation of National park and reserves.

Tourism management and planning

The Tourism sector is currently guided by the 2018 National Tourism Policy with the vision to make Eswatini "a preferred tourism destination and a leader in sustainable tourism". The purpose of the National Tourism Policy is to provide a framework that guides the structure, operations, management, and development of the Eswatini tourism industry through six main principles:

1. Sustainable, Responsible & Ethical Tourism
2. Competitive & Market Driven Tourism
3. Partnership, Cooperation and Coordination
4. Quality and Value Driven Tourism
5. Rural Development & Community Involvement
6. Improved Quality of Life & Benefits for All

The National Tourism Policy specifies the need for the formulation of a Tourism Act to govern the sector and strengthen legal and regulatory compliance as well as the review of existing legislation and regulations. Overall, the lead body for the enforcement of the National Tourism Policy is the Ministry of Tourism and Environmental Affairs (MOTEA) which oversees the department of tourism and the department of environment. In addition to these departments, two tourism parastatals play a particularly important role in the development and management of tourism activities, namely the ETA and the ENTC.

- The Eswatini Tourism Authority (ETA) is mandated to develop the tourism sector as a national priority through promotion of Eswatini as a tourism destination and facilitating tourism investment including community-based tourism. This mandate is articulated through five key strategic objectives, namely:
  - To provide leadership in the tourism industry and marketing representation at international, regional and local forums, and coordination between the government and private sector;
  - To generate tourism data research and provide information services;
  - To stimulate product development;
  - To facilitate tourism industry human resource development and enhance employment opportunities, and;
  - To provide internal management, planning and administration and source funding.
- The Eswatini National Trust Commission (ENTC) is responsible for conservation of the Kingdom's natural and cultural heritage. The ENTC carries out its mandate through proclamation and management of national parks and reserves, national museums and monuments. The Trust Commission presently administers:

- Swaziland National Museum
- King Sobhuza II Park
- Mantenga Nature Reserve and Cultural Village
- Malolotja Nature Reserve, with the adjacent Hawane Dam Reserve
- Mlawula Nature Reserve with Magadzavane Lodge

The wildlife legislation in Eswatini is fragmented and there are several pieces of legislation that address various aspects of wildlife conservation such as the institutional framework, protected areas and protection of a specific class or specific classes of species. The Environment Management Act (EMA) is the country's overarching law on the environment and it serves as the national framework for environmental protection and management including that of wildlife. However, the provisions that deal more specifically with the protection and regulation of wildlife are found in older sectoral laws.

- The laws that establish administrative structures for the management of wildlife include the National Trust Commission Act (NTCA), the Swazi Administration Order (SAO), the Safeguarding of Swazi Areas Act (SSAA) and the Natural Resources Act (NRA).
- The laws that protect wildlife and wildlife products include the Game Act, the Wild Birds Protection Act (WBPA), the Private Forests Act (PFA) and the Flora Protection Act (FPA).

3

THE ESWATINI TOURISM VALUE CHAIN

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THE ESWATINI TOURISM VALUE CHAIN

A supply chain is the process of all parties involved in fulfilling a customer request, while a value chain is a set of interrelated activities a company, or an industry such as tourism, uses to create a competitive advantage. The focus of a tourism value chain is therefore less on cost reduction in the supply chain and more on seeking ways to leverage value-adding opportunities. Therefore, a tourism value chain exists when all the stakeholders in the chain operate in such a way as to maximize the generation of value along the chain.

Figure 6 – Eswatini's Tourism Value Chain



Accommodation

Categories	#	Rooms
Backpackers	4	42
Camping	11	108
Lodge	25	388
B&B, SC, Chalets	82	633
Guest house	44	387
Village stay	1	2
Hotel	28	1450
Total	**191**	**3010**

E 184 millions

Amenities

Categories	#
Fast Food	69
Dinning place	54
Total	**123**

E 193 millions

Attractions

Arts | Entertainment
Conferencing & Recreation

Categories	#
National Park	1
National reserves	10
Ramsar sites	3
UNESCO-MAB biosphere res.	1
Major tourist crafts centres	4
Community tourism products	7
Total	**26**

E 88 millions

Access

Categories	#
Airlines	2
Car rental	11
Shuttle services	9
Total	**22**

E 0,8 millions

Activities

Categories	#
Travel Agencies	7
Tour operators	24

E 19 millions

Source: Compiled by Authors from ETA database

The purpose of this section is to describe both the demand and supply sides of the Eswatini tourism industry starting with a market segmentation approach to identify (and later target) existing groups of visitors. For all of the visitors to Eswatini, the experience consists of a series of individual experience points provided by different entities known as the 5 A's: Access, Accommodation, Attractions, Activities, and Amenities.

In the description of each of these entities, reference will be made to backward linkages with agriculture, the craft industry, etc. This is in order to explore the opportunities that the tourism sector could offer local communities in terms of jobs and income.

The visitors - A market segmentation approach

This market segmentation approach is based on the request of the Eswatini Tourism Authority to focus on six key international source markets: South Africa, Mozambique, France, Germany, the Netherlands, and the United Kingdom. Despite having access to a wealth of information regarding visitor experiences and sentiments, a detailed exploration into the size, characteristics, and travel behaviors of potential market segments from these countries have remained largely untapped.

While the current data provides a solid starting point, future market segmentations will benefit from regularly updated data. There is a need for more detailed information on visitor spending patterns, the impact of digital marketing on travel decisions, and the effectiveness of current tourism products in meeting visitor expectations. Additionally, more granular data on the preferences of different demographic groups will enhance the accuracy of future segmentation efforts.

Though the intention of this project is to increase length of stay, it needs to be stated again that **for many visitors, Eswatini remains a transit market.** While there is a potential area for growth in converting transit visitors into longer-staying tourists, that would be a long-term project. Feedback from tour operators, crucial stakeholders in the tourism ecosystem, further emphasizes this point with a need for products and packages around stays of 4+ days [section 6.2.4]. While Eswatini is often included as part of larger travel itineraries, there is a substantial opportunity to develop offerings that do more than encourage visitors to extend their stay - they open Eswatini up as a destination to new market segments.

Eswatini market analysis

Following the three-step process for building a portfolio analysis management model outlined in the Methodology section, this segmentation starts from the short-haul regional neighbors and important long-haul markets identified by the Eswatini Tourism Authority and is based on visitors' primary demographic information (visit reason, length of stay, age, group size, perception, etc.). This will be done in light of the objective of increasing length of stay, so subsegments from each source country that help to meet this goal will be isolated.

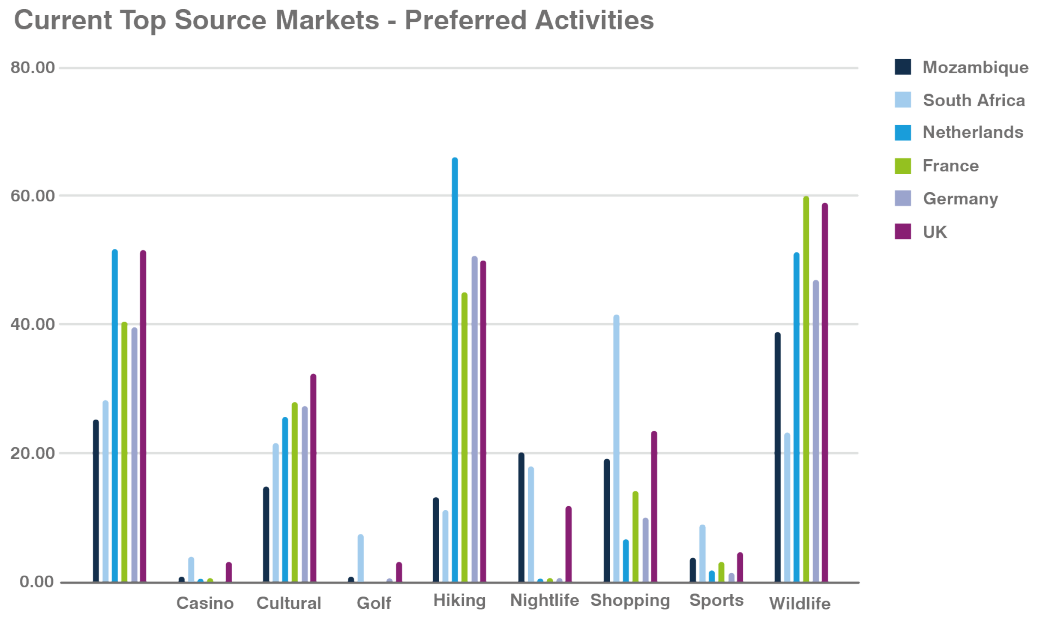
This approach not only aids in developing a marketing mix that appeals to specific groups but also ensures the segmentation's relevance and applicability over time. The focus on natural, reproducible, and constructive clustering/ segmentation aligns, based on effective market segmentation strategy best practices (see annex) with the need to match the destination's offerings with identifiable tourist groups, leveraging segmentation based on tourist characteristics relevant to Eswatini's tourism products and services.

The formulation of market segments for Eswatini, incorporating data from the 2023 and 2024 exit surveys, the online portal, testimonies from tourism stakeholders, and international databases, is intended to provide a deeper understanding of key visitor demographics, their motivations, satisfaction levels, and specific interests. This analysis, based on information collected from firsthand accounts of visitors, starts from current trends, behaviors, and perceptions to allow a path forward.

Overview of the top six markets

To begin our market segmentation, we can start by looking at one of the areas highlighted by the exit surveys: visitor activities. By looking at these country preferences side by side, we can better understand the varying demands of different traveler demographics and begin to form targeted marketing segments. This overview allows us to identify common trends across markets, as well as unique preferences that may be specific to certain countries.

Figure 7 – Preferred activities of top source markets



Source: ETA database

From the data collected, several larger insights emerge about how holiday/leisure travelers engage with Eswatini:

- **Wildlife and Hiking:** These two activities are prevalent across nearly all surveyed markets. Specifically, wildlife viewing is most popular among French and UK travelers, suggesting these markets might be particularly receptive to marketing campaigns. Hiking, especially prevalent among German and UK tourists, points to opportunities for promoting Eswatini's scenic trails and natural landscapes.

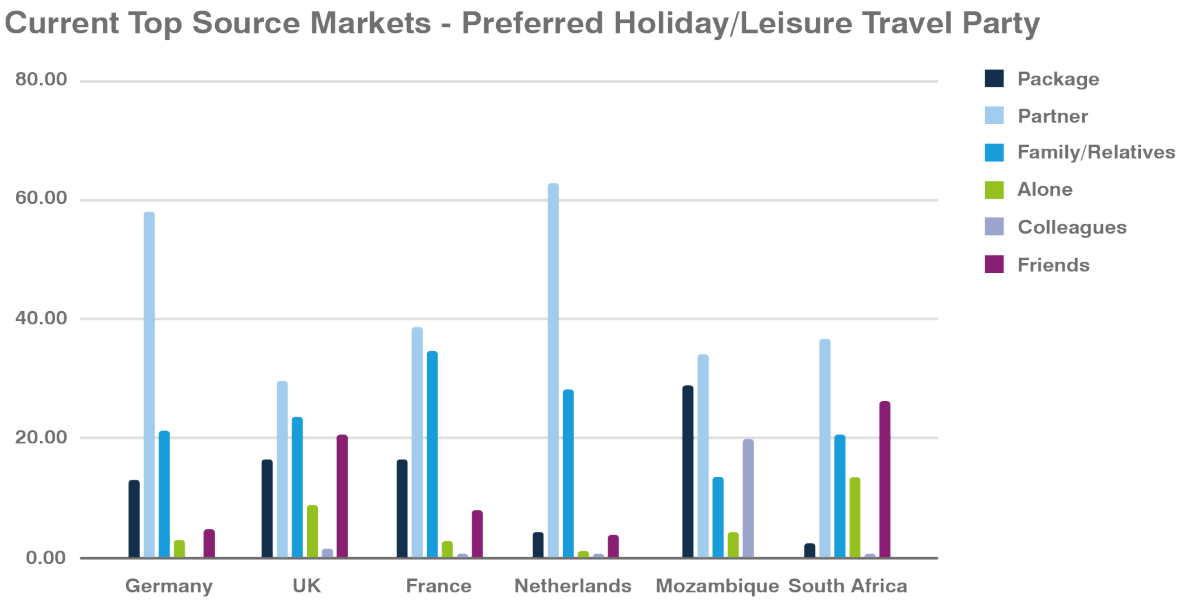
- **Adventure:** This activity is a common interest not just among international travelers from Germany, France, the UK, but also among regional neighbors South African and Mozambique. The broad appeal of adventure activities, ranging from safari drives to adrenaline-pumping experiences like zip-lining or rafting, suggests a versatile market segment that Eswatini can target with adventure tourism packages.

- **Cultural Experiences:** While cultural activities are less dominant compared to wildlife and adventure, they still represent a significant interest across all markets, especially the UK. This interest in cultural experiences offers Eswatini the chance to showcase its unique heritage, traditions, and local community initiatives.

- **Shopping and Nightlife:** Shopping is of less interest to international travelers, with the exception of visitors from the UK. Nightlife, however, stands out in the preferences of South African and Mozambique travelers, indicating a market segment that could be already coming for evening entertainment. Tailoring marketing messages to highlight local crafts markets, shopping, and daytime adventures could encourage those already coming to spend even more time.

The same overview is useful for these markets' preferred travel party arrangements. Knowing who the segments tend to travel with can help guide marketing strategies and outreach.

Figure 8 – Preferred Holiday/leisure travel party



Source: ETA database

A few larger themes emerge, including:

- **Preference for Partner and Family Travel:** Across all six markets, traveling with a partner or family/relatives is the most common choice. German and Dutch travelers show a particularly strong preference for partner-based travel, while family-oriented trips are most common among Mozambique, South African, and French travelers. This

trend underscores a significant opportunity for Eswatini to promote packages around romantic getaways or family-friendly adventures.

- **Varied Interest in Group Travel:** The data reveals varying degrees of interest in traveling with friends or as part of a package tour. The UK market stands out with a relatively higher inclination towards traveling with friends and opting for package tours, suggesting a market segment that may appreciate group travel deals or social travel experiences. Package tours have less appeal among Dutch and German travelers, indicating a preference for more personalized or independent travel experiences, which can impact the kinds of tour agencies sought for partnerships.

- **Solo Travel and Other Niche Markets:** Solo travel appears to be less common across the board, it's notably more prevalent among UK travelers. This presents a niche market segment interested in solo adventures, which could be tapped into with tailored experiences promoting personal growth, adventure, and self-discovery.

Market segmentation by country

German Travelers

German traveler growth has followed the general visitation trend to Eswatini, going from 3,992 in 2022 to 9,874 in 2023, a 147.4% increase year-over-year. Maintaining this level of growth may not be feasible on an annual basis, but what is possible to understand from these travelers is their preferences based on activities and age groups, as well as how that is related to their average length of stay.

By looking at the relationship between average length of stay and activity preferences, it's possible to shape potential target market segments. Taking the average length of German holiday/leisure travelers as baseline (1.56 nights), a few positive outliers can be identified. Notably, adventure and wildlife activities appear to encourage longer stays among younger adults (25-34 years), while middle-aged tourists (45-54 years) show a predilection for hiking and cultural activities.

Table 6 – Potential German markets segments

Potential German Market Segments		
	Segment 1: Young Adults For Adventure & Wildlife	**Segment 2: Families Seeking Cultural & Natural Experiences**
Age Groups	25-34 years	Families within the 45-54 age group
ALOS + Activities	Adventure (2.04 days) and Wildlife (2.18 days), compared to 1.56 for German holiday/ leisure travelers.	Wildlife (Average Length of Stay: 2.04 days), Adventure (Average Length of Stay: 2.04 days), and overall 1.96 nights as a group compared to 1.56 for German holiday/leisure travelers.
Getting Information	More than the average German traveler, this age group got information from travel agents (69.29%). Other sources include the Eswatini tourism website (8.57%), social media like Instagram (5.71%) and Facebook (4.29%), and friends (5%).	Finding out through agents remains the most prominent form of contact, with 68.75% of German family travelers saying this is how they found out about their trip.
Awareness	Just 2.86% of German holiday/leisure travelers said they 'Already Knew' about Eswatini, lower than the 8.10% of all German travelers, suggesting room for growth.	Just 1.94% of German holiday/leisure travelers ages 45-54 said they 'Already Knew' about Eswatini, lower than the 8.10% of all German travelers, suggesting room for growth.

Source: ETA database

French Travelers

In 2023, arrivals to Eswatini from France increased from 15,090 to 5,938 in 2022, a 154.1% growth rate. By looking more closely at the exit surveys that accompanied a portion of these visits, including how average length of stay of certain age groups and travel parties relates to their chosen activities, it is possible to identify market segments for French visitors.

Table 7 - Potential French market segments

Potential French Market Segments		
	Segment 1: Families Looking For A Balanced Trip	**Segment 2: Young Adult Hikers and Cultural Enthusiasts**
Age Groups	45-54. Of all French holiday/leisure travelers, families make up 34.38% of the travel groups. Of this 45-54 set, though, that rises to 51.85%, suggesting that a balanced mix of adventure, culture, hiking, and wildlife can appeal to the family.	25-34. Nearly a quarter (23.65%) of French holiday/leisure travelers are in this age range.
ALOS + Activities	Wildlife (1.83 days), adventure (1.82 days), and hiking (1.73 days) were all above the average of 1.55 for French holiday/leisure travelers.	Hiking (2.08 days) and Culture (2.70 days) were much higher than the 1.55 average for French holiday/leisure travelers, indicating that those engaging with Eswatini's cultural heritage and outdoor assets had a tendency to spend more time.
Getting Information	A slightly higher than average 'Already Knew' (7.64% to 5.23%), which corresponds with a higher usage rate of the Website (17.78%), to go along with Agents (62.96%) and Newspapers (8.33%).	This age group had the lowest reliance on travel agents (59.68% to 63.67% for French holiday/leisure travelers), as well as the highest figure for hearing from friends (8.06% to 5.27% average).
Awareness	Compared with their average, French holiday/leisure travelers have a slightly higher awareness of Eswatini (7.64% replied 'Already knew' compared with 5.23%).	Compared with their average, younger French holiday/leisure travelers have a slightly lower awareness of Eswatini (3.23% replied 'Already knew' compared with 5.23%).

Source: ETA database

UK Travelers

The number of visitors from the UK to Eswatini increased to 7,519 in 2023 from 4,695 in 2022, a growth rate of 60.2%. Despite a slightly smaller sample size of 113 traveler exit surveys (1 survey for every 66 travelers) compared with France (554 surveys, or 1 survey for every 27 travelers), the relative proportions between UK travelers can still provide insights into their preferences and behaviors.

Table 8 - Potential UK market segments

Potential UK Market Segments		
	Segment 1: Mature Adventure and Wildlife Enthusiasts	**Segment 2: Young Adults Seeking Adventure and Wildlife with Friends**
Age Groups	45-64 (a larger age group to include more representative sample)	25-34
ALOS + Activities	Adventure: Combining ages 45-54 (4.43 days) and 55-64 (8.80 days) and Wildlife: 45-54 (3.38 days) and 55-64 (9.00 days)	Adventure (4.13 days), Wildlife (4.33 days)

Getting Information	With 30% already knowing about Eswatini, UK travelers are finding out either through friends (45-54: 14.29%, 55-64: 12.5%), travel agents (45-54: 47.62% , 55-64: 25%), or the website (45-54: 9.52%, 55-64: 25%).	This group primarily gets its information from Friends (53.85%), which suggests that word-of-mouth is highly effective.
Awareness	Though slightly lower than the UK overall rate of 43.46% for 'Already Knew', these two age groups (45-54: 30.0%, 55-64: 37.5%) suggest a much higher penetration of awareness.	Respondents in the 18-24 and 25-34 range were less aware than the average UK traveler of Eswatini.

Source: ETA database

Netherlands Travelers

The increase in tourist arrivals from the Netherlands to Eswatini, from 6,687 in 2022 to 16,254 in 2023, represents a growth rate of 143.1%. With 1,047 traveler exit surveys representing these arrivals, it's possible to create segments for Dutch travelers based on activities, travel parties, and lengths of stay.

Table 9 - Potential Netherlands market segments

Potential Netherlands Market Segments		
	Segment 1: Couples Seeking Hiking and Wildlife	**Segment 2: Adults Seeking Adventure and Wildlife with Friends**
Age Groups	Predominantly 55-64, couples (partner travel constitutes 62.77% of Dutch travelers)	45-54
ALOS + Activities	Dutch holiday/leisure travelers with interests in Adventure (1.74 days), Wildlife (1.82 days), Culture (1.58 days), extending over the average Dutch holiday/leisure traveler of 1.57 days. 55-64 partners also traveled 1.74 days on average.	Dutch holiday/leisure travelers 45-54 with interests in Wildlife (1.82), Adventure (1.60), and Hiking (1.61). Family travelers in this age range spend an average of 1.64 days.
Getting Information	The Dutch holiday/leisure travelers between 55-64 are less reliant (56.58%) in their use of travel agents for information (71.23% for all Dutch travelers to Eswatini), with higher than average knowledge of the destination beforehand (10.53%), suggesting strong word of mouth.	76.69% of Dutch holiday/leisure travelers get their information from travel agents, with the next highest source being the Eswatini website (10.53%).
Awareness	On average, only 4.56% of all Dutch travelers said 'Already Knew' about Eswatini before arriving. The 55-64 age range is above this at 10.53%, while the travel agent rate is lower at just 56.58%, which suggests outreach can be more individual and about informing options.	At just 2.45%, awareness of Eswatini for the 45-54 age group is below the average for Dutch holiday/leisure travelers, suggesting this market needs to be introduced to the destination through general efforts.

Source: ETA database

Mozambique Travelers

The increase in tourist arrivals from Mozambique to Eswatini, from 59,126 in 2022 to 125,176 in 2023, is equivalent to a growth rate of 111.7%. The average length of stay for a visitor from Mozambique is just 0.86 days. However, one identifying as a holiday/leisure traveler nearly doubles that length of stay to 1.61 days. An analysis of their travel preferences, travel parties, and interests can help to segment these travelers further.

Table 10 - Potential Mozambique market segments

Potential Mozambique Market Segments		
	Segment 1: Families Interested In Wildlife & Culture	**Segment 2: Young Adult Friends For Adventure & Nightlife**
Age Groups	55-64	25-34, 35-44 years
ALOS + Activities	Wildlife is higher than ALOS for each age group, peaking at 2.75 for 55-64; Culture peaks at 3.0 days for 55-64	Friend groups in these age ranges are higher than average (25-34: 1.75 days, 35-44: 1.64 days), as well as the ALOS for holiday/leisure travelers in these ranges, including Adventure (25-34: 1.83 days, 35-44: 1.77 days) and Nightlife (25-34: 2.00 days, 35-44: 2.17 days).
Getting Information	This specific bracket shows a much higher prevalence for using the website (13.33% to an average Mozambique usage of just 4.48%), as well as getting information from Friends (33.33%, compared to 19.06% overall).	These groups show an even higher propensity to get information from friends (25-34: 42.42%, 35-44: 36.21%), as well as through the newspaper (25-34: 15.15%, 35-44: 10.92%).
Awareness	As a market, Eswatini's neighbors largely know about Eswatini, with 74.55% saying they already knew.	Both of these holiday/leisure groups responded at 50% or higher that they already knew Eswatini, which is lower than the overall Mozambique average and suggests more could be done to promote these specific activities.

Source: ETA database

South Africa Travelers

The increase in South African tourists visiting Eswatini, from 348,628 in 2022 to 547,025 in 2023, is equivalent to a growth rate of 56.9%. On average, the South African visitor spends 1.85 days in Eswatini, while those identifying as holiday/leisure travelers spend 2.09 days. The primary source provinces for holiday/leisure travelers are Gauteng (40.36%), Mpumalanga (27.69%), and Kwazulu Natal (11.12%). In Gauteng, the two largest sources of "Holiday/Leisure" travelers, 35-44 and 45-55, are within the 45-54 age range. Given Gauteng's substantial contribution to the visitor numbers, focusing on activity preferences, travel parties, and age ranges from visitors in these ranges can lead to strong potential marketing segments.

Table 11 - Potential South Africa market segments

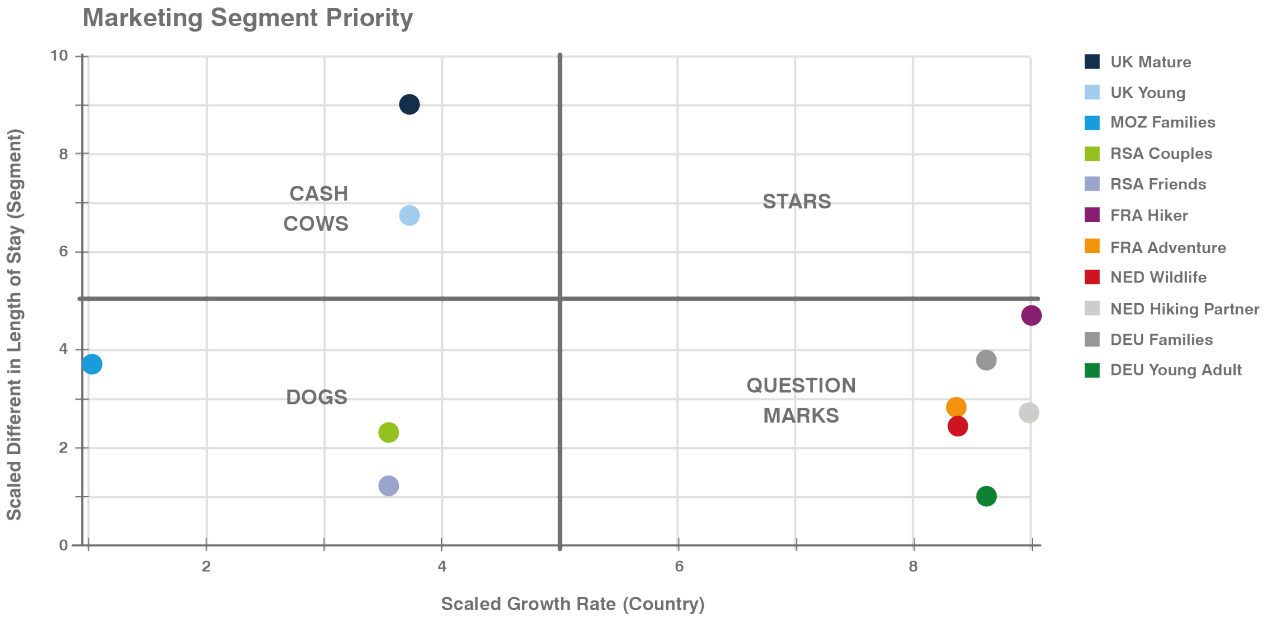
Potential South Africa Market Segments		
	Segment 1: Couples Seeking Unique Experiences	**Segment 2: Young Adult Friend Groups**
Age Groups	45-54	25-34
ALOS + Activities	In this age range, South African holiday leisure travelers tend to enjoy Adventure activities (2.35 days), Shopping (2.23 days), Wildlife (2.25 days). Couples make up the biggest portion (34.46%) of this age range.	In this age range, South African holiday leisure travelers tend to enjoy Nightlife activities (2.56 days), Adventure (2.65 days), and Wildlife (2.76 days). Behind Partners (41.11%), Friends make up the next biggest portion (31.67%) of this age range.
Getting Information	The top sources for information include Friends (3.59%), Facebook (2.39%), and Newspaper (1.51%).	Compared with how South African travelers in general get information, and holiday/leisure, this specific age group has a higher portion hearing from Friends (9.44%).
Awareness	With a high awareness (92.47% of holiday/leisure travelers), the outbound focus can be placed on specific products or packages.	90% of the South African holiday/leisure travelers in this age group responded that they 'Already Knew' about Eswatini.

Source: ETA database

Marketing Segment Priority

Though based on the BCG Matrix and its four quadrants - Stars (High Growth, High Market Share), Cash Cows (Low Growth, High Market Share), Question Marks (High Growth, Low Market Share), and Dogs (Low Growth, Low Market Share) - this market segmentation uses ALOS as a proxy for market share, as a market share would necessarily be based on data that is still heavily impacted by the tourism sector's recovery (e.g. year-over-year growth rates of target markets between 60-154%). **Priority here should be given to choosing the most attractive subsegments of Eswatini's current top six markets** as an indicator that will not only inform ways to increase average length of stay, but as **a foundation for how to develop packages and products that can attract new holiday/leisure markets willing to spend 4+ days,** as requested by international tour operators.

Figure 9 – Market segment priorities



Source: Authors

Taking the quadrant system into account, these marketing subsegments fall into the following sections:

Cash Cows	Dogs	Question Marks	Stars
Lower growth, high engagement = stability without need for significant investment	Lower growth areas and lower engagement = Lower potential for profitability	High growth potential but uncertain engagement levels = need right strategy to succeed	High growth potential and high engagement = the ideal combination for strategic investment
UK Mature (45-54) UK Young (25-34)	MOZ Families (45-54) MOZ Nightlife (25-34) RSA Couples (25-34) RSA Friends (25-34)	DEU Young Adults (25-34) DEU Families (45-54) FRA Hiker (25-34) FRA Adventure (45-54) NED Wildlife (45-54) NED Hiking Partner (55-64)	

The majority of segments being categorized as "Question Marks" in this adapted BCG Matrix analysis highlights a common scenario in growing markets. These segments, while situated in potentially high-growth areas, exhibit moderate levels of engagement, indicating untapped potential. The presence of most segments in the "Question Marks" quadrant signals an opportunity for targeted strategies aimed at converting these into "Stars" by increasing their market engagement. These strategies could include customized marketing campaigns, enhanced customer experiences, or **product development tailored to the specific needs and preferences of each segment.** The goal should be to **leverage the inherent**

growth potential of these markets by fostering deeper connections with the segments, thereby increasing their engagement and average length of stay, as well as gaining access to new markets.

The suppliers

Accommodations

Accommodation's categories in Eswatini are defined by the Swaziland Tourism Authority Act (2001) and the amendment of the regulations for the grading of tourism accommodation establishments (2016). Therefore, accommodation establishments shall be categorized into the following classes:

(a) Backpackers hostels;
(b) Bed and breakfast establishments;
(c) Campsites;
(d) Camping and caravan parks;
(e) Guest houses;
(f) Hotels;
(g) Rest camps; and
(h) Self-catering establishments.
(i) or any other accommodation establishment that the Registration Authority may approve.

According to data from ETA (2023), hotels account for 15% of the total and 45% of rooms. Throughout Eswatini, 46% of accommodation providers are located in three main towns: Mbabane, Matsapha and Manzini. Sometimes classified as lodges, self-catering establishments are on rise especially in reserves and parks (Shewula, Nkonyeni Gold Estate, Jozini) with the aim of offering a unique experience to visitors, who can drive themselves or walk in complete safety among the flora and fauna. However, the average room occupancy rate is fairly low for all destinations in Eswatini (29.9%) with the lowest rate in the capital (Manzini - 17.5%) and the highest in the countryside (42%).

44% of accommodations have conference rooms offering good prospects for MICE tourism, provided they can provide good internet access and sufficient space. At present, the largest room in operation can only accommodate 450 people.

With regards to sustainability, big hotels located in Eswatini have a clear performance measurement tool to assess their performance. However, the small and medium hotels (SMHs) have challenges to use such tools to measure their performances (Dlamini et al. 2020).

Amenities

There are 54 and 69 registered restaurants and fast-food outlets respectively in Eswatini. Once again, the majority of establishments are located in Eswatini's three main towns (72% for restaurant establishments and 43% for fast-food establishments). In general, if restaurants mainly source local produce, access to local gastronomy is not very important.

Some explain this by the fact that local people don't go to restaurants very often. However, it is still difficult to find typical local dishes in many hotels and restaurants. To return to the question of cross-sector links and the potential impact of tourism, there is local production of meat, vegetables and fruit to supply the market. However, it is clear that restaurants need to be made aware of the need to promote gastronomy and the use of seasonal produce.

Accessibility

Eswatini can be reached by air or overland. Until recently, reaching Eswatini by air was only possible from Johannesburg, flying to King Mswati III International airport on Airlink. With the new national airline, serving the country with aircraft seating a maximum of 50, Eswatini Air offers now direct & non-stop flights to:

- OR Tambo International Airport (JNB) in Johannesburg, South Africa
- Cape Town International Airport (CPT, South Africa

- King Shaka International Airport (DUR) in Durban, South Africa
- Robert Gabriel Mugabe International Airport (HRE) in Harare, Zimbabwe

Otherwise, the majority of international visitors to Eswatini enter the country by land. Two ports of entry (Ngwenya in the West and Lavumisa in the South-East) represent more than half of the border crossing (56.6%). Other major ports of entry are located in the North (Matsumo - 10.7%) and North-East (Lomahasha - 14.9%). Currently, 11 car rental companies and 9 shuttle services operate in Eswatini.

Although Eswatini has an international airport capable of handling wide-bodied aircraft, it is unlikely that direct flights from Europe will be available soon.

Attractions

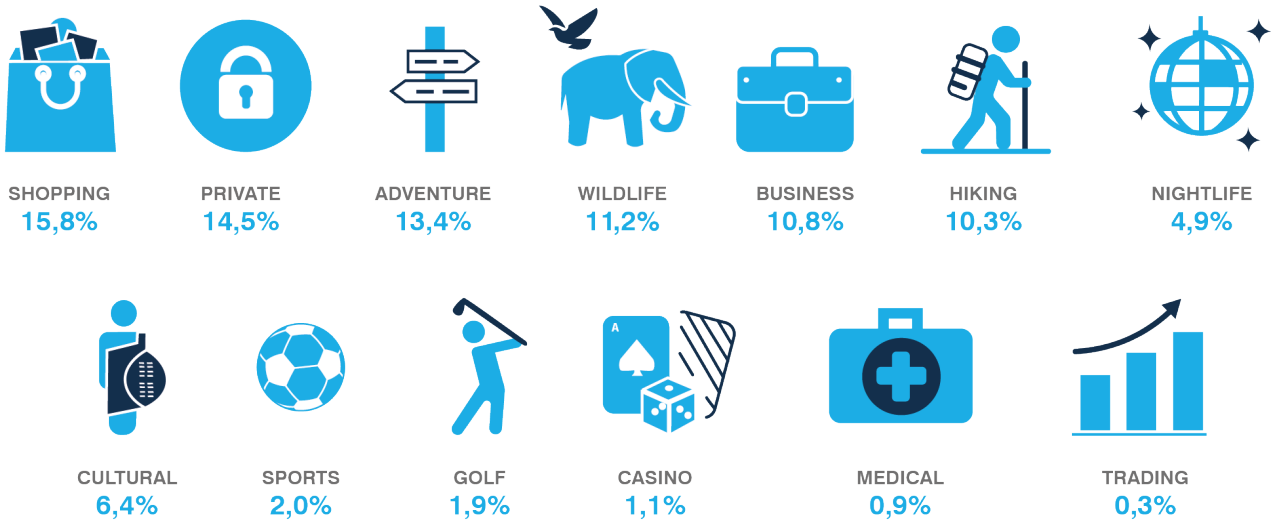
The Kingdom of Eswatini has many attractions, starting with its flora and fauna, described earlier in this document. While conservation projects have made it possible to see white and black rhinos in the same vicinity, Eswatini can hardly compete with wildlife products/destinations such as Kruger National Park in South Africa.

Eswatini has however a unique variety of handicraft products ranging from basketry, mats, ceramics, beads, pottery, hand textiles, woven products, toys, to jewelry, bags, ornaments, leather products, batiks and wood crafts, among others. These items are produced in different parts of the country and often supported by NGOs such as “Gone Rural”.

Activities & Experiences

According to the ETA annual report (2023), visitors to Eswatini mostly engage in shopping activities and in private businesses. Adventure tourism and wildlife tourism (nature-based activities) come next, leaving cultural activities far behind, probably due to a lack of visibility of the activities or an underdeveloped offer. In fact, many hotels and other accommodation facilities tend to present community tourism activities such as visits to schools or orphanages to meet the expectations of visitors interested in making donations.

Figure 10 - Distribution of visitors activities



Source: ETA

The following paragraphs attempt to explain in more detail the activities undertaken by visitors according to their category on the basis of testimonies gathered during field visits. Thus, for many visitors passing through (transit) or spending the night in Eswatini, the activities are very similar, with a visit to the Ngwenya glass factory and the Swazi candle-making center. Over time, these two production centers have been the driving force behind a diversification of the activities on

offer to visitors, with the development of a craft market (Swazi Candles) and the addition of souvenir shops and catering services. However, the time spent in these premises still remains limited. A dozen of crafts shops or initiatives have however benefited from the success of these crafts centers allowing for a broader impact of visitors' expenditures (see - https://www.thekingdomofeswatini.com/arts-craft-artisans-providers/).

For visitors staying more than one night, the itineraries remain fairly similar, with visits to the same craft centers plus activities depending on visitors' interests:

- Malandela cultural village
- Ngwenya Old Mine
- Manzini historical tour including the Stone church Museum

Otherwise, other activities are more nature-based offering sometimes linkages to communities. Hiking trails are on offer in and around the main cities in the country but also in several nature reserves. For group tourists, these activities are organized by foreign operators or one of the Kingdom's 24 tour operators. Most non-African visitors showed a trend of liking to engage in adventure, wildlife and interestingly more hiking.

4

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SITUATION ANALYSIS

Tourism competitiveness

In this report, we adopt an hybrid approach of competitiveness that integrates two dimensions of competitiveness namely the comparative and competitive advantage. The comparative advantages of a destination are related to the resources and capabilities of a destination to compete, and which can be collected from the WEF's Travel and Tourism Competitiveness Index sub-indices and pillars. On the other hand, the competitive advantages are related to the performance achieved of a destination (efficacy) (González-Rodríguez et al. 2023).

Comparative advantage

The 2019 Travel and Tourism Competitiveness Index (TTCI) covers 140 countries. It offers a good overview of the competitiveness of any destination worldwide. Eswatini was unfortunately not covered in the TTCI 2021 because of insufficient data. Indicators derived from the World Economic Forum's Executive Opinion Survey are always expressed as scores on a 1–7 scale, with 7 being the most desirable outcome.

Figure 11 – Travel and Tourism competitiveness

		ENABLING ENVIRONMENT					T&T POLICY & ENABLING CONDITIONS				INFRASTRUCTURE			NATURAL & CULT. RESOURCES	
	Global Rank	Business Environment	Safety & Security	Health & Hygiene	Human Resources & Labor Market	ICT Readiness	Prioritization of T&T	Int'l. Openness	Price Compt'ness	Environ. Sustainability	Air Transport Infrastructure	Ground & Port Infrastructure	Tourist Service Infrastructure	Natural Resources	Cultural Res. & Business Travel
South Africa	61	4.6	3.9	3.7	4.4	4.6	4.5	2.5	5.6	3.7	3.3	3.5	4.3	4.5	3.2
Namibia	81	4.8	5.0	3.5	4.4	4.2	4.8	2.8	5.7	4.3	2.9	3.4	4.6	3.5	1.2
Botswana	92	4.9	5.3	3.3	4.3	4.1	4.8	2.3	6.0	4.3	2.1	2.8	3.6	3.4	1.2
Zambia	113	4.4	5.3	2.6	3.8	3.2	3.9	2.9	5.1	4.4	1.8	2.4	2.5	3.6	1.3
Zimbabwe	114	3.3	5.4	3.0	3.6	3.2	4.2	3.0	5.3	4.1	1.8	2.3	3.0	3.6	1.3
Eswatini	118	4.4	5.5	3.1	3.8	2.3	4.6	2.7	6.1	3.7	2.2	3.1	3.0	2.2	1.0
Lesotho	124	4.1	5.4	3.0	3.6	3.2	5.1	2.6	6.1	4.8	1.3	1.8	2.8	2.2	1.0
Angola	134	3.5	5.0	3.2	3.2	2.3	3.2	1.9	5.3	4.1	1.7	2.0	2.7	2.2	1.2
Southern Africa Average		4.2	5.1	3.2	3.9	3.4	4.4	2.6	5.7	4.2	2.1	2.7	3.3	3.2	1.4

Source: TTDI (2019)

Overall, the Kingdom of Eswatini is ranked 118 out of 140 countries in terms of travel and tourism competitiveness. It ranks fairly well in terms of price competitiveness (ranked first amongst its competitors), but very poorly in terms of cultural and natural resources. This is mainly due to the absence of internationally labeled resources, such as World Heritage sites. Eswatini has however embarked on a journey to have its first World Heritage Site nomination. Thus, Eswatini currently collaborates with South Africa on the potential extension of *Barberton Makhonjwa World* Heritage site located in the northwestern part of the country. Preserving and promoting natural and cultural resources, particularly through labeling, are important factors in raising the profile of tourist destinations.

The destination's other weaknesses lie in its tourism infrastructures, with no direct air access and a limited number of hotel facilities. Although tourism has been established as a priority in national policy, there are still constraints for businesses including access to trained or skilled human resources. However, in terms of new technologies (ICT), Eswatini is the eighth African country to benefit from Starlink's commercial services. Starlink is expected to help bring high-speed Internet access to more people and businesses in Eswatini. According to the latest statistics from data platform DataReportal[4], there were 710,300 internet users in the Kingdom at the beginning of 2023. This figure represents a penetration rate of 58.9%.

Finally, the Kingdom of Eswatini is also the safest and most secure in the region, characteristics that deserve to be promoted to counterbalance the often-negative image of South Africa in terms of these criteria. This aspect is also reflected in the participatory definition of what differentiates the country from its competitors (see figure below). Culture, the people and

4 https://datareportal.com/

their friendliness are recurring key words in the stakeholders' perspective of their country compared with their competitors.

Figure 12 – Eswatini's USP for tourism stakeholders



Source: ITC-ETA Workshop (Feb. 2024).

Competitive advantage

The competitive advantage relates to tourism infrastructure, the quality of management, the skills of the workforce, supporting industries and the role of government policy. Therefore, it involves determining the managerial capabilities (as predictors) that best explain the competitive advantage of a destination in terms of efficiency, which can also be collected from the TTCI. In this section, we will be looking more closely at the destination's results in terms of competitiveness, and more specifically in relation to its main regional competitors. To do this, we use a more precise approach to quantitative tourism competitiveness which is the comparative advantage ratio (CAR) that is derived from comparing two ratios: the absorption rate of a host country of tourists from a particular market and the share of that particular market's arrivals in the competing destinations.

Table 12 - Comparative advantage ratio for Eswatini

OUTBOUND REGIONS	Africa		Americas		East Asia and Pacific		Europe		Middle East		South Asia	
INBOUND COUNTRIES	**2014**	**2019**	**2014**	**2019**	**2014**	**2019**	**2014**	**2019**	**2014**	**2017**	**2014**	**2019**
Eswatini	1,138	1,149	0,405	0,366	0,337	0,316	0,560	0,546	nc	0,116	0,888	1,086
South Africa	0,976	0,962	1,078	1,167	1,023	0,962	1,076	1,137	1,473	1,562	1,429	1,281
Botswana	1,124	1,072	0,718	0,941	0,633	0,834	0,489	0,696	0,418	0,293	0,587	0,529
Zimbabwe	1,088	1,056	0,839	0,938	1,180	1,520	0,560	0,607	0,716	0,905	0,158	0,613
Namibia	1,011	1,033	0,566	0,518	0,514	0,462	1,248	1,192	nc	0,000	nc	0,000
Zambia	0,989	1,049	1,113	0,866	2,518	1,721	0,605	0,501	nc	0,000	2,760	2,631
Lesotho	1,208	1,208	0,239	0,211	0,649	0,655	0,160	0,228	0,271	0,166	0,528	0,474
Angola	0,227	0,186	3,319	3,197	3,682	3,887	4,016	3,764	6,490	11,939	1,561	4,277
Mozambique	0,924	0,898	1,461	1,321	0,435	0,986	1,488	1,555	nc	0,000	nc	0,000

Source: Authors using ONU tourism statistics.

Eswatini has a competitive advantage in a particular market if the share of international tourists from that market is greater than the average. The average here is defined as the share of outbound tourists from that market in all competing destinations if the ratio is greater than 1 - this means that Eswatini is a relatively preferred destination compared to competing destinations as a whole.

For example, **Eswatini was a relatively preferred destination for tourists from South Asia and Africa** in 2019 or has a competitive advantage in this market, the proportion of tourists from these two areas of origin compared to the total number of tourists that visited Eswatini being greater than the share of tourists from South Asia and Africa in competing destinations. In other words, **the absorption of tourists from South Asia and Africa by Eswatini was greater than the absorption of tourists from these two areas by the competing destinations in neighboring South African countries.** From the table above, Eswatini had only a competitive advantage in the African market (1,138) in 2014 meaning that Eswatini's share of African tourists was 1.138 times greater than the share of these categories of outbound tourists in the entire group of countries. **On the other hand, in 2019, Eswatini has made small progress, with a higher share of leisure tourists from South Asia compared to 2014 and to the share of the same tourists in the region.**

Despite some progress in 2017 in the leisure markets of Europe and the Americas, including a higher absorption rate for the European market (1,031), Eswatini does not have a comparative advantage for the major leisure markets.

Perception of Eswatini as a tourism destination

To understand and enhance the perception of Eswatini as a tourism destination, we employ a multifaceted approach that combines digital insights and traditional data sources to offer a comprehensive analysis.

From the digital side, the traveler's perception of Eswatini's tourism sector spans more than just its official website and social media platforms. It also includes the content created by travelers, the reviews posted, the sentiments attached to those reviews, among others. This network of touchpoints offers data on how the destination is discovered, explored, and experienced by its audience. Understanding this perception involves examining search intent, engagement metrics, and the sentiment expressed across these digital platforms, platforms that not only serve as the first point of contact for many potential tourists but also play a role in guiding them through the stages of buyer readiness, from initial awareness to the final decision to visit.

Complementing the digital analysis, traditional data sources such as exit surveys provide direct feedback from visitors, offering insights into their experiences, perceptions, and the likelihood of recommending Eswatini to others.

Table 13 – Approach for improving the understanding of the destination perception

Objectives	Activities
Objective 1: Search intent and digital presence	- Assess the ranking and position of Eswatini's Destination Management Organization (DMO) website among its target audience, using search engine rankings as a proxy for visibility. - This metric, as suggested by Xiang and Fesenmaier (2005), will help gauge the initial reach and impression made on potential tourists. - Analyze search traffic and engagement metrics on Eswatini's tourism website and social media platforms to assess where potential travelers fall within the buyer readiness stages.
Objective 2: Search trends by market	- Leverage Google Analytics and SEMRush data to identify the top nationalities visiting Eswatini's tourism websites and their search volume trends. - Perform a competitive analysis to understand how Eswatini performs in comparison with regional destinations
Objective 3: Sentiment analysis	- Use sentiment analysis to evaluate the emotional tone and perceptions expressed by tourists and potential visitors in online reviews, social media mentions, and other digital platforms. - Analysis will provide insights into the overall sentiment towards Eswatini as a tourism destination and identify areas for improvement or amplification in marketing strategies.

Source: Authors

By understanding the digital behaviors and preferences of potential tourists, aligned with the firsthand experiences of past

visitors and the perceptions of the tour companies that connect visitors to the destination, this analysis aims to uncover the factors that influence the decision-making process and the overall sentiment towards Eswatini.

Search intent & digital presence

Eswatini's digital presence serves as a critical touchpoint for engaging with tourists at various stages of their journey, from initial awareness to the decision to visit. This journey can be mapped along Kotler et al.'s (2009) stages of buyer readiness: awareness, knowledge, liking, preference, conviction, and purchase. Each stage presents an opportunity for tourism marketing to effectively reach and influence the tourist's decision-making process.

Xiang et al. (2014) further delineate the tourist's online journey into three stages: pre-travel, consumption, and post-consumption. These stages encapsulate the evolving needs of tourists, from seeking information for planning and decision-making, to connecting with service providers and executing transactions at the destination, and finally to sharing their experiences post-visit.

Keywords by intent

Understanding the tourist's journey through the digital landscape starts with an analysis of search intent, which is the motive behind every query entered into a search engine. Search intent can be categorized into four main types: informational, navigational, transactional, and experiential. **Each type of intent aligns with different stages of the tourist's decision-making process, offering insights into what potential visitors are looking for at each step**. By identifying and analyzing the keywords based on their underlying intent, tourism marketers can tailor their content strategy to meet the needs of tourists more effectively, ensuring that Eswatini's digital presence engages visitors across all stages of their journey.

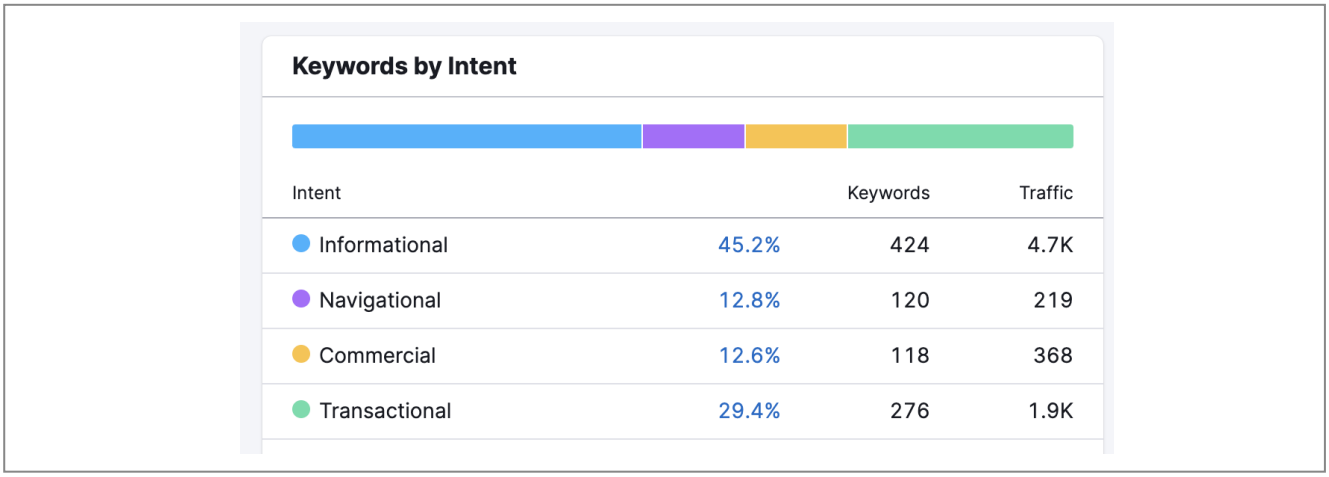
Figure 13 – Tourist's decision-making process



Source: authors

Below we have a breakdown of the keywords by intent as provided by Semrush, an internationally used tool and platform that specializes in keyword research and competitor analysis. This breakdown shows the percentage of each intent type of the keywords in the Google top 100 that are leading to www.TheKingdomOfEswatini.com. It reveals not only the diversity of tourists' needs and interests but also highlights opportunities for Eswatini's tourism marketing to enhance content relevancy and user engagement.

Figure 14 – Breakdown of keywords by intent for searching Eswatini



Source: Worldwide results for TheKingdomOfEswatini.com, Semrush, Mar. 1, 2024

By understanding the four types of keyword intent, we can see the kinds of searches that are leading to the official tourism website for Eswatini, and how this lines up with industry standards.

For a general destination management website, the primary focus should ideally be on informational and navigational intents. These sites should serve as comprehensive resources for learning about the destination and easily navigating to specific information or affiliated services.

While some content may align with commercial intent, such as highlighting tours or special deals, DMOs typically aim to inform and guide rather than directly sell.

Transactional intent is normally advised for booking platforms or service providers directly offering reservations, tickets, or purchases.

Table 14 - Comparing Search Intent: Eswatini vs Regional Competitors

Country	Informational	Navigational	Commercial	Transactional	Organic Search Traffic
Eswatini [thekingdomofeswatini.com]	45.2%	12.8%	12.6%	29.4%	13.9k
South Africa [southafrica.net]	48.6%	14.6%	18%	18.7%	357k
Rwanda [visitrwanda.com]	74.2%	9.9%	8.6%	7.3%	43k

The benchmark comparison reveals differences in how each destination aligns with the various types of search intent. Eswatini and South Africa show a more balanced distribution across informational, navigational, commercial, and transactional intents, whereas Rwanda demonstrates a significant lean towards informational intent. This indicates that Rwanda's digital presence is more aligned with providing detailed, informative content that caters to users seeking knowledge about the destination.

For destination management websites, a high percentage of commercial intent traffic can indicate that users are frequently engaging with the site for comparison or deal-seeking purposes, which might not always align with the primary goal of such sites—to inform and guide visitors rather than directly facilitate transactions.

While commercial intent can drive valuable engagement, focusing too heavily on it might divert resources from enhancing informational content, which is crucial for building awareness and interest in the destination. An overemphasis on commercial content can overshadow the broader narrative of the destination's unique cultural, natural, and historical assets.

Benchmarking with Regional Destinations

Table 15 - Benchmarking with regional destinations

Country	Est. Monthly Visits	Pages/Visit	Bounce Rate
Eswatini [thekingdomofeswatini.com]	6.7k	1.6	84.77%
South Africa [southafrica.net]	178.1k	1.2	95.17%
Rwanda [visitrwanda.com]	43.6k	1.8	73.88%
Botswana [botswanatourism.co.bw]	8.5k	2.1	21.18%
Namibia [visitnamibia.com.na]	15.7k	2.3	84.93%

Source: Compiled by authors.

The **bounce rate** is the percentage of single-page sessions in which users left the site from the entrance page without interacting with the page. In certain instances, this can indicate that they found the information they needed and left. In others, it suggests that there was no interest in exploring for further information. Similarly, **pages/visit** is the number of pages an average visitor to the website looks at. In this benchmarking, South Africa has a very high number of monthly visits, but since the vast majority are leaving after one page, as suggested by the 95.17% bounce rate, then a small portion are exploring enough to keep their pages/visit above one.

Lower pages per visit, as is the case for Eswatini and South Africa, could indicate that visitors aren't finding the content they're looking for, the website lacks depth in content offerings, or the organization doesn't naturally lead users to additional information. Understanding how users navigate through the site can highlight popular content, potential bottlenecks, and opportunities to guide visitors toward conversion goals more effectively.

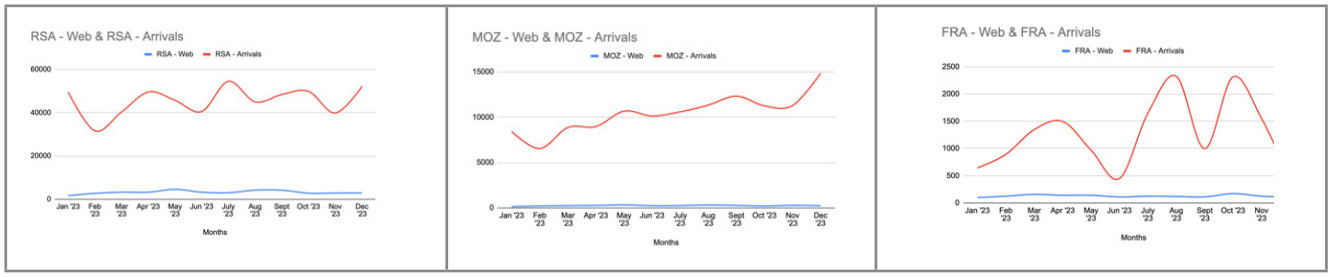
Search trends & market segmentation

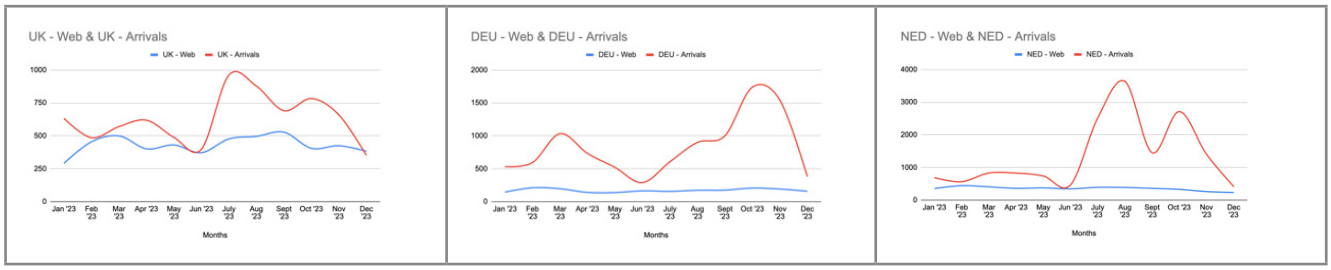
Engagement metrics offer a lens through which the effectiveness of Eswatini's digital content can be assessed. Low bounce rates and high engagement levels signify content relevance and alignment with visitor expectations, guiding the tourism department in optimizing online strategies. By analyzing search queries and volumes through Google Search Console and SEMRush, insights into what potential tourists seek—from attractions to logistics—are better understood. This direct feedback highlights the importance of tailoring the website's content to match potential visitors' search intents, enhancing SEO performance, and ensuring Eswatini stands out as a premier destination.

Volume of visitors to Eswatini vs. volume of visitors to website

One way to measure the effectiveness of online and traditional marketing strategies in source markets is to see the relationship between web traffic to www.thekingdomofeswatini.com and actual tourist arrivals. Below is the correlation between the volume of visitors to Eswatini's official tourism website and the number of tourists arriving from the requested markets: South Africa, Mozambique, France, UK, Germany, and the Netherlands. For an additional comparison and data point, the US market is added below.

Figure 15 – Correlation between volume of visitors to Eswatini's website and international arrivals





Source: Authors

Takeaways from each source market:

- **South Africa** - Substantial web traffic, along with high numbers of arrivals, suggests a correlation between web engagement and visits. This could indicate the website is reaching Eswatini's neighbor effectively.

- **Mozambique -** Significantly lower web traffic, along with high arrivals, suggests that there is less reliance on the website for information. This could be due to language barriers (www.thekingdomofeswatini.com is only available in English, while Portuguese is the official language of Mozambique), as well as an existing familiarity with the market (74.55% of Mozambicans said they 'Already Knew' about Eswatini in their exit survey responses, and just 4.48% referenced the website).

- **France -** French tourists follow clear spikes, yet this isn't matched by any related increase in web traffic. While the French do report using the website more often (16.25% from exit surveys), it seems to be used for general information gathering.

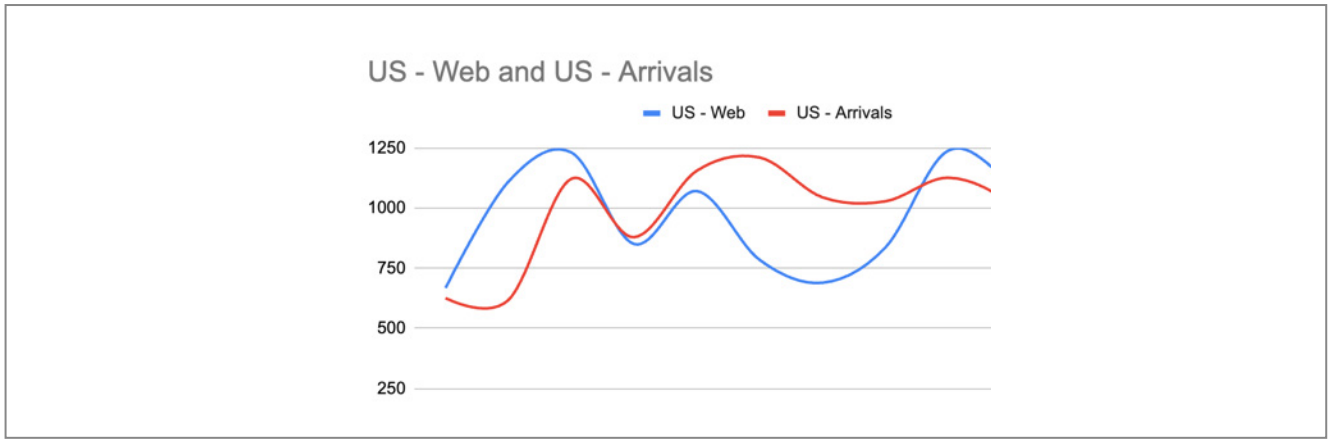
- **UK -** The data here begins to show a moderate, but not fully deterministic, relationship between website visits and arrivals. Web traffic doesn't necessarily spike with the highest arrivals, suggesting that the website plays a part in travel planning but is not used by all travelers. This is supported by the demographic difference in website usage, ranging from 7.69% (UK holiday/leisure travelers from 25-34) to 37.5% (55-64).

- **Germany -** There is a correlation between web visits and tourist arrivals, though the October and November tourist arrivals don't have a proportionate rise in web visits. Given that only 8.10% report an awareness of Eswatini, the reliance on travel agents (64.18% for all German travelers) and lack of German-language websites could limit overall effectiveness.

- **Netherlands -** There's a disparity between web traffic and tourist arrivals, especially in July and August. This suggests that while the website can play a role in trip planning, other factors like direct recommendations or travel agencies might be more influential.

Given that one hypothesis is about how visitors from non-English speaking countries may be interacting with the site, it is useful to see a comparison with the US as another English-speaking market to reference.

Figure 16 - Correlation between volume of visitors to Eswatini's website and international arrivals from US citizens



Source: Compiled by Authors

There is a noticeable alignment between peaks in web traffic (especially in March, September, and October) and increases in tourist arrivals, though the highest number of arrivals is seen in June, not perfectly aligning with the highest web traffic month. This could indicate that while the website plays a significant role in travel planning for US visitors, decisions to travel might also be influenced by factors such as vacation timing or specific events. Unlike some of the other markets where web traffic didn't always align with arrival spikes (notably the Netherlands and France), the US data suggests a closer correlation between interest online and actual visits, albeit with some lag or lead times.

Overall, markets closer to Eswatini or with strong linguistic ties (e.g., South Africa, US) show a more direct correlation between web engagement and tourist arrivals. This suggests that the website is effectively reaching and influencing these audiences.

For certain markets, especially those in Europe like the Netherlands and France, there's a less direct correlation between website traffic and tourist arrivals. This indicates that while the website is a part of the decision-making process, other factors such as personal recommendations, travel agencies, or cultural connections might play a larger role in influencing travel decisions.

Analyzing search behaviors and trends

One way to understand the digital impact of www.thekingdomofeswatini.com is to see the breakdown of traffic to the site from each country by direct visits versus organic search results. Visitors that come from organic searches are those who are looking up information and clicking through the search results to end up on the website. Direct site visits are those that know exactly what they're looking for, and visit the site by typing its name directly in, or visit from a bookmark.

Table 16 – Direct site visits and ratio per priority markets

Country	Organic Search Visits	Direct Site Visits	Ratio (Direct/Organic)
South Africa	31,086	7,450	23.97%
Mozambique	2,514	581	23.11%
France	1143	405	35.43%
Germany	1410	499	35.39%
UK	4138	961	23.22%
Netherlands	3025	870	28.76%

Source: Compiled by authors

The ratios across all countries show that direct site visits constitute a significant portion of the total traffic. However, the direct visits are consistently lower than organic search visits, indicating that **organic search remains a crucial driver for website traffic across these markets.**

The higher direct visit ratios in countries like France and Germany, compared to the lower ratios in South Africa, Mozambique, and the UK, could suggest that the overall volume of organic search traffic is influenced by the site's visibility and relevance in search results, which might be affected by language and localization factors.

By examining the specific phrases and terms that users from target markets are entering into search engines, it's possible to understand what they're looking for and when they're looking for it, be it general information about the destination ("Eswatini tourism"), specifics on accommodations ("hawane resort"), unique events ("reed dance"), or natural attractions ("malolotja nature reserve"). This helps to understand the existing perception of Eswatini as a tourist destination but also highlights opportunities for improvement.

Table 17 - Top 10 Search Keywords from Each Market

South Africa	Mozambique	France	UK	Netherlands	Germany
Swazi rally 2023	Hlane royal national park	Mantenga cultural village	Swaziland shopping	Malolotja nature reserve	Malolotja nature reserve

South Africa	Mozambique	France	UK	Netherlands	Germany
Mantenga cultural village	Mantenga cultural village	Hlane royal national park	Swaziland shopping	Mantenga cultural village	Mantenga cultural village
Swaziland	Malolotja nature reserve	Mlilwane wildlife sanctuary	Eswatini	Mlilwane wildlife sanctuary	Eswatini tourism
Malolotja nature reserve	Mlawula nature reserve	Malolotja nature reserve	Malolotja nature reserve	Eswatini tourism	Mantenga nature reserve
Eswatini	Hlane national park	Mlilwane rest camp	Eswatini tourism	Hawane resort	Mlawula nature reserve
Reed dance 2023	Eswatini tourism	Mlawula nature reserve	Mbabane	Mkhaya game reserve	Swaziland
Umhlanga reed dance	Sibebe resort	Eswatini tourism	Mlilwane rest camp	Kingdom of eswatini	Eswatini
Eswatini tourism	Mlilwane wildlife sanctuary	Mkhaya game reserve	Eswatini kitchen	Ezulwini valley	Reed dance
Reed dance	Ezulwini	Mantenga nature reserve	Reed dance	Hlane royal national park	Eswatini visa on arrival
Hawane resort	Sibebe rock	Visit eswatini	Hlane royal national park	Mantenga nature reserve	Reed dance swaziland

Source: Compiled by authors

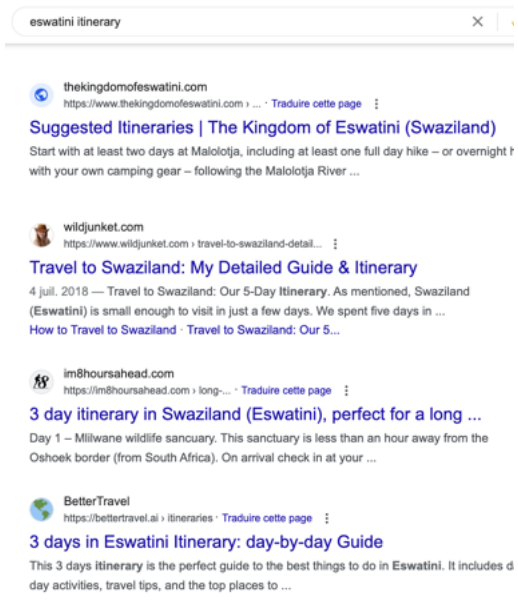
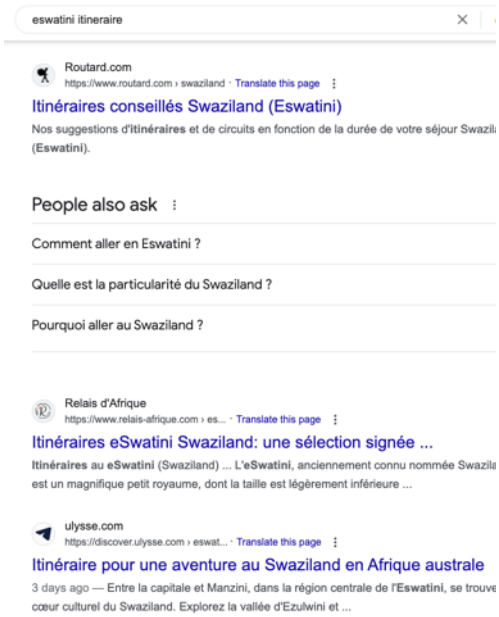
Keywords like "Swazi Rally 2023," "Reed dance 2023," and "Umhlanga reed dance" from the South African market indicate an interest in Eswatini's cultural events and traditional ceremonies. That's also seen in other markets, including Germany, which suggest that Eswatini's cultural heritage is perceived by more than just its regional neighbors.

There is an occurrence across all markets for natural reserves like "Malolotja Nature Reserve," "Hlane Royal National Park," and "Mlilwane Wildlife Sanctuary", confirming Eswatini's perception as a destination with natural assets. There are also a number of results on www.thekingdomofeswatini.com for specific accommodations, including "Hawane Resort," "Sibebe Resort," and "Mantenga Cultural Village''. While these indicate that visitors are using the website for trip planning purposes, these transactional keywords, in some cases, may be better leading visitors to the relevant sites themselves. That they don't also suggests a potential weakness in the local stakeholders.

Language considerations

The prevalence of English keywords across all markets, including four non-English speaking countries like France, Germany, Mozambique, and the Netherlands, suggests that there is some comfort using English to search for information. However, www.thekingdomofeswatini.com has little to no visibility in the native search languages.

Table 18 – Performance of ETA website

"Eswatini Itinerary"	"Eswatini Itinéraire"
	
"Eswatini itinerary" leads to the Suggested Itineraries page on www.thekingdomofeswatini.com as the first result	The search for "Eswatini itinéraire" does not return any pages from www.thekingdomofeswatini.com in at least the first 60 results.

This is seen by the lack of search terms in native languages, including French, German, Portuguese, or Dutch, in the Google Search Console report. This is a result of the Eswatini tourism website not supporting any other languages, meaning search terms from those languages will not lead travelers to the site.

We can see an example of this when searching for a term in English ("Eswatini itinerary") and in French ("Eswatini itinéraire") to see the difference in results a small change can lead to.

Other sites have information in French about itineraries to Eswatini. **Relying on other sites to provide that information means a missed opportunity for the Eswatini tourism website to communicate directly with this market,** and by extension, other foreign markets.

Engagement metrics and content relevance

Through Google Analytics, we can understand how users from different countries engage with www.TheKingdomOfEswatini.com, then use differences in the following metrics to understand how the site is resonating with audiences from those regions and inform strategies for how to enhance its relevance.

Table 19 – Engagement metrics for priority markets

Country	Users	Engaged Sessions	Engagement Rate	Engaged Session/User	Avg. Engagement Time
France	1,671	2,167	62.4%	1.30	3m 18s
Netherlands	3,926	5,114	68.92%	1.30	3m 08s
United Kingdom	5,210	6,127	62.5%	1.18	2m 52s
Germany	2,084	2,370	64.35%	1.14	2m 50s
South Africa	39,525	55,042	62.04%	1.39	2m 52s
Mozambique	3,106	4,805	61.75%	1.55	3m 30s

Source: Compiled by authors.

Averages for the site include a 61.92% engagement rate, 1.36 engaged sessions per user is 1.36, and an engagement time of 3m 02.

Engagement Rate

The engagement rate, or the percentage of engaged sessions ("The number of sessions that lasted longer than 10 seconds, or had a conversion event, or had 2 or more screen or page views"), ranges from Mozambique on the lower end of the selected markets to Netherlands on the higher end, implying that the content or user experience is particularly resonant with this audience.

Engagement Sessions

Engaged sessions per user is intended to show how often users return or stay engaged during their interactions on the site. Mozambique, at an average of 1.55, suggests users have a higher interest rate or satisfaction level, or are more often searching for information.

This contrasts with the United Kingdom and Germany, suggesting that despite a decent level of initial engagement, there could be room to increase engagement or prolong the duration of each visit.

Engagement Time

This measures how long users stayed engaged during their session. This is measured by Google as "the average length of time that the app was in the foreground, or the web site had focus in the browser." Interestingly, the average times for France and Netherlands, two countries that don't have English as an official language, have higher average engagement times than the United Kingdom.

Informing market segmentation

To expand on the engagement rates and indeed, use them to better align with traditional and offline marketing techniques, it's also important to understand the pathways through which traffic arrives at the site. If a significant portion of traffic is direct, that is, users entering the URL directly or clicking a non-search link to arrive at the site, it can indicate a strong brand awareness in a destination. Viewed from the other side, a destination that relies heavily on search-driven traffic could suggest visitors are in the exploratory phase and relying on online content to make their decisions, rather than just support them.

Sentiment analysis

Sentiment analysis aims to ascertain a writer's attitude towards a subject or the general polarity of a text document within its context, with sentiments then grouped into positive, neutral, and negative. In a tourism context, this allows us to gauge the emotional tone behind tourists' feedback and online discussions about Eswatini. By using the sentiment analysis tool text2data, a platform that uses NLP/Deep Learning (Natural Language Processing) along with proprietary algorithms to deliver text analytics on a cross-section of online reviews (e.g., TripAdvisor, Google Reviews) and exit survey, we can begin to identify trends in positive or negative sentiments.

Analyzing online reviews

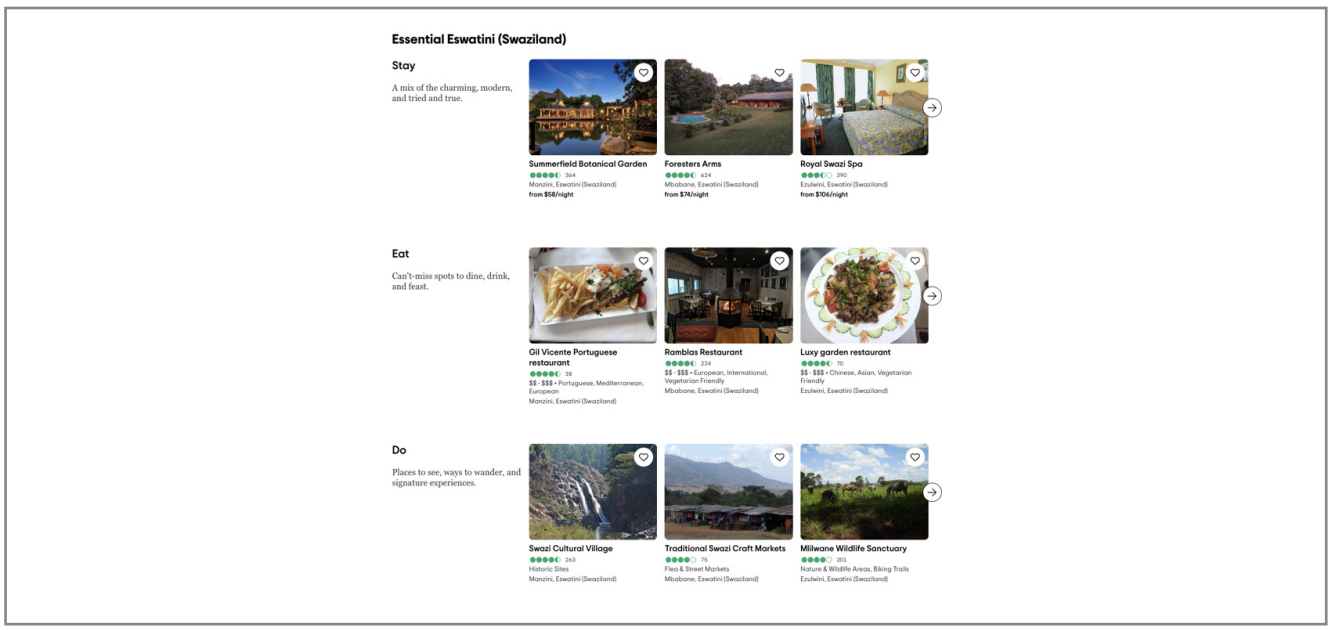
Regarded as one of the most important sources of information for travelers, word-of-mouth referrals, user-generated content, and reviews play a significant part of a destination's perception. One of the primary sources for this information is TripAdvisor. In the last 10 years, TripAdvisor has grown from 200 million reviews to over 1 billion. This includes ratings on over eight million travel-related entities, including hotels, activities, and more that are accessed by hundreds of millions of travelers monthly (About TripAdvisor).

Through performing sentiment analysis on ratings and textual feedback on hotels, activities, and attractions within Eswatini, we aim to identify overarching feelings, trends, and patterns that can inform the current perception of Eswatini as a destination, while also providing a path forward on how to craft that perception.

Methodology

Our analysis spans 300 reviews sourced from Eswatini's Top 10 hotels, restaurants, and activities, found on the Explore Eswatini destination TripAdvisor page.

Figure 17 - How Travelers See The "Explore Eswatini (Swaziland)" Section of TripAdvisor



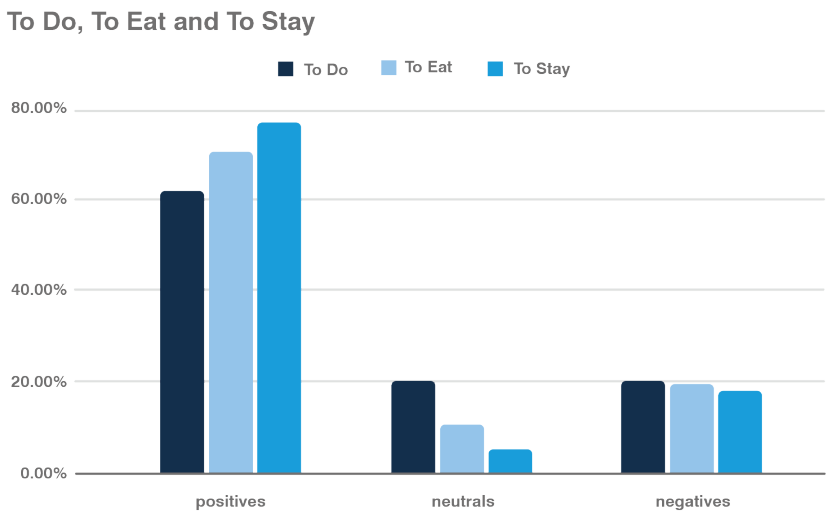
Source: Screenshot from TripAdvisor, March 8, 2024.

The decision to specifically consider the top 10 establishments and their most recent 10 reviews is based on TripAdvisor's research that finds that "respondents in Russia and Japan were the only two markets to prefer to read multiple pages of reviews to get an overall sense of people's opinions." Since those two markets are the exception, **the vast majority of travelers read only the reviews that are presented to them when accessing a listing without having to load additional pages, or the first 10**. By focusing on the most reviewed establishments, we capture the initial impressions and predominant sentiments that travelers encounter when researching Eswatini online. This approach allows us to gain insights into the perception of the destination.

In addition to the semantic analysis performed on these 300 reviews, general information is provided in the annex on the providers, the most recent review date, and how responsive management has been in publicly handling these reviews. Review recency and management responsiveness to reviews plays a significant role in influencing potential travelers' decisions. Data shows that **53% of TripAdvisor users may refrain from booking a hotel that entirely lacks reviews.**

Further affecting the perception is how management responds to reviews. **87% of users agree that an appropriate response to a negative review enhances their impression of the hotel,** while **62% are more inclined to book when they see management engaging,** compared to hotels that do not respond to travelers' feedback.

Figure 18 - Sentiment Analysis of Eswatini's Presence on TripAdvisor

	To Stay | Accommodations	To Do | Activities	To Eat | Restaurants
Avg. Rate of Response	32%	3%	14%
Median Rate of Response	15%	0%	0%
Sentiment of Reviews			

Source: Compiled by authors

Before addressing the sentiment analysis for the attractions in Eswatini, it's important to recognize a notable challenge that can significantly impact visitor perceptions and experiences: the management and promotion of these attractions online. **In Eswatini, 90% of the top 10 attractions' pages are either not claimed or not actively managed**. This lack of active management and ownership (just one has commented on recent reviews, and only a few times) can lead to visitors perceiving these attractions as neglected or not accessible, which is a critical factor in shaping the overall image and appeal of a destination.

The consequences of this situation become evident when analyzing visitor feedback and satisfaction levels. For instance, **positive sentiment for attractions in Eswatini stands at 61%, which is noticeably lower compared to the 70% positivity rate for restaurants and an even higher 77% for accommodations.** This disparity suggests that while visitors find dining and lodging experiences in Eswatini to be relatively satisfactory, the attraction segment appears to lag behind, possibly due to the issues related to management and presentation. It could be that critiques are made that, with the proper effort to address, could lead more people to respond positively.

Traveler Perception of Eswatini Accommodations

Positive reviews show both **the strengths of the accommodation offer in Eswatini while also suggesting areas for improvement** for a comprehensive understanding of the guest experience. One hotel is lauded for its integration with nature, clean accommodations, and good dining facilities ("a truly wonderful place from where to explore the Kingdom of Eswatini" - Sentiment score: 0.677), while noting the absence of spa facilities, a gap in the offering - and potentially in the market - that could help to strengthen the destination. Another hotel receives a mostly positive review that notes the lack of clear communication regarding room reservations ("there is nothing she could do because they were fully booked. However, on Booking.com there were multiple larger rooms available." - Sentiment score: 0.54) and the need for better clarity and service at the dining facilities.

Reviews containing **negative sentiments reveal dissatisfaction with safety, security, quality of service, and food**. For instance, one review expresses disappointment with the dining experience at a supposedly first-class hotel ("Everything about this hotel spoke out to me as first class. The reason why we could not give it a five-star review was because of the service and food in the dining area" - Sentiment score: -0.631). Another was off put by construction work, which interfered with their stay ("This hotel was under construction and we had no idea. No place to gather and the food was the worse." - Sentiment score: -0.526). These suggest a gap between guest expectations and service provided, **emphasizing the need for hotels to ensure visitor experience align with the hospitality expectations**, and to be communicative in order to make sure those expectations are reasonable.

Traveler Perception of Eswatini Activities

Many visitors are **captivated by Eswatini's breathtaking landscapes, from mountain top views across valleys to the beauty of Sibebe Rock and Malolotja Reserve.** Reviews highlight the stunning vistas and the beauty of the region ("The views are wonderful, and I loved the flowering wattle and unique fir trees.", +0.535). The **craftsmanship and quality of local artisanal products receive high praise,** making places like Tintsaba excellent for finding authentic Eswatini souvenirs ("If you looking for something to take back home that screams I was in Eswatini, Tintsaba is one of the best places to look up.", +0.587).

Attractions that offer insights into Eswatini's history and culture, like the oldest mine in the world and traditional Swazi villages, are appreciated for their educational value and the opportunity to engage with the country's heritage ("This trip is a gem in the rough.", +0.677). The availability of outdoor activities, including hiking, wildlife safaris, and canopy tours, is highly valued ("Lovely wildlife sanctuary with good quality dirt roads for a 2WD.", +0.716).

Negative encounters with management and staff, such as disrespectful behavior and inadequacies in addressing visitor complaints, are common, including problems with site managers at campsites ("He actually said that we 'looked like' we were going to 'make plenty of noise.'", -0.569; "We were very disappointed with the staff here.", -0.541). **Concerns about maintenance and cleanliness,** including bed bugs in accommodations and untidy areas at entry points, detract from visitor satisfaction ("The place where you pay and hire a guide is not the nice place, very messy and untidy.", -0.565). Negative experiences related to other tourists' conduct, such as drinking on tours, highlight the **need for better management of visitor behavior** ("Fellow tourists were drinking on the tour, and that wasn't nice for a family...", -0.983).

A lack of clear information and guidance, including insufficient signage and unclear directions, confuses visitors ("You must arrange for a guide in advance...you run the risk of getting lost", -0.609;), and is connected to challenges with accessibility and infrastructure, such as difficult driving conditions and the necessity for 4WD vehicles. There are also concerns over the commercialization of cultural experiences and the authenticity of local crafts and souvenirs are evident ("items are more or less the same and some of the locals can be quite pushy.", -0.622; "Not a lot of variation among the shops.", -0.486).

Traveler Perception of Eswatini Restaurants

The positive reviews of restaurants in Eswatini highlight several key themes that contribute to exceptional dining experiences: **a welcoming atmosphere, good value, unique experiences, scenic locations, and the likelihood of recommendations and repeat visits.** Reviews frequently mention the cozy and welcoming ambiance ("As soon as you enter the restaurant you feel like a guest invited into someone's home" - Sentiment score: 0.597). While some customers noted that the food might seem expensive by local standards, others felt that the prices were reasonable, especially from a European perspective.

Negative reviews of restaurants in Eswatini revolve around **customer service, food quality and presentation, menu variety and dietary options, value for money, ambiance, and operational efficiency.** From reviews mentioning the owner not being warm or welcoming and negatively impacting the dining experience ("The owner/manager lurked around the bar was not very warm or welcoming and seemed more interested in a laugh with staff" - Sentiment score: -0.615) and quality control issues to dietary considerations and comments about value for money suggest that travelers with international experience and other reference points find certain qualities of the offer in Eswatini lacking.

Sentiment analysis of visitor exit surveys

Among the objective information collected in the exit surveys, including visitor nationality, residency, length of stay, and activities participated in, the survey offers the opportunity for several subjective and open-ended responses. Continuing with the use of the sentiment analysis tool text2data, particularly when applied to exit surveys, enables us to parse through free-text responses where visitors express their thoughts and feelings in their own words. This automated process allows for the processing of large volumes of data, providing a comprehensive overview of tourist sentiments. The results are then aggregated to identify overarching themes and trends.

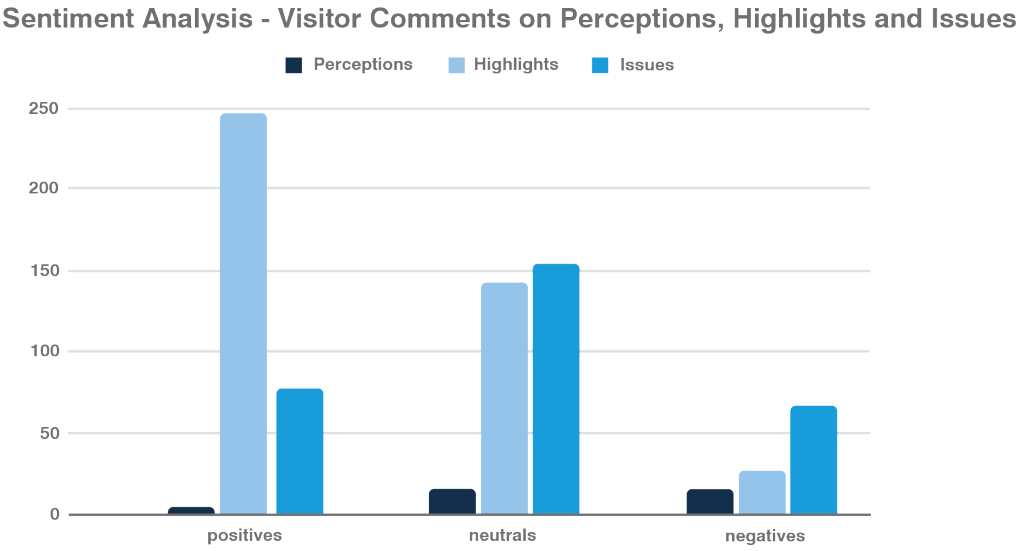
The three main questions involve the perceptions of visitors to Eswatini before the visit, the highlights of the visit, and issues that arose during the visit. In addition to a number of multiple-choice options for each question (full list available in Annex 4), visitors could choose 'Other' and respond. Below, we will analyze those that added detail to their survey responses.

Table 20 – Sentiment analysis of visitor exit surveys

Perceptions Before Visit	Highlights of Visit	Issues of Visit
"What were your perceptions of Eswatini prior to arrival in the country?"	"What were the highlights of your stay in Eswatini?"	"What issues did you have, if any, during your stay in Eswatini?"
57 responses	429 responses	553 responses

Source: Eswatini Tourism Authority 2023 Exit Surveys.

Figure 19 - Sentiment analysis of visitor exit surveys



The results present an overview of visitors' perceptions of Eswatini before and during their trip. Prior to arrival, **pre-arrival perceptions were a mix of neutral and negative, highlights were predominantly positive and neutral, and issues were mostly neutral and negative**. As the graph above shows, there were positive, neutral, and negative sentiments in each of the three groups of responses. This range of feedback can seem paradoxical - how can there be negative highlights, or issues that have positive sentiment - yet it is part of the nature of this analysis. Comments have nuance. Negative sentiment in highlights can reveal areas of unmet expectations, just as issues with a positive sentiment suggest

that tourists perceive opportunities for the destination to improve.

1. **Perceptions of Eswatini Before the Visit**

   The initial analysis reveals that visitor perceptions of Eswatini trend negative. Criticisms include negative sentiments around "weather temperatures," "more rural" aspects, and "nothing interesting" to do or see. The "crime rate" and views of the country as "boring" and "less developed" with scores ranging from -0.513 to -0.737, highlight areas that could be addressed. On the positive side, sentiments such as "likes the country" and "good country" demonstrate a general appreciation for Eswatini, with scores of 0.686 and 0.678 respectively.

   While Eswatini has strengths to build upon, **negative perceptions regarding development, safety, and entertainment, suggest that improvements needed** to change the destination's perception and enhance tourist satisfaction

2. **Highlights from the Visit**

   The positive feedback extracted from the surveys reveals **a strong sentiment toward the country's diverse offerings, affordability, and hospitality.** High sentiment scores for "amazing bike rally," "AMAZING new year celebration," and "beautiful and unique handcrafts" show that **Eswatini's events, landscapes, and culture are having a deep impact on visitors.** There is also repeated praise for how accessible the country is, with numerous mentions of "good value for money" across various services and products, showing that **Eswatini is perceived as a budget-friendly destination that doesn't compromise on quality or experience.**

   Despite these responses happening under the 'Highlights' section of the exit survey, the analysis did pick up negative sentiment. Of the negative-trending responses, themes such as "improved country than I expected," "lots of improvement," and "more developed than I expected" suggest that tourists arrived with preconceived notions about Eswatini lacking in certain areas. The surprise and recognition of that development and the absence of issues like drought or corruption indicate that tourists' expectations were surpassed, which, while positive, also contains a negative element.

3. **Issues Encountered During the Visit**

   Issues of infrastructure and signage were prominent, with tourists expressing difficulty in navigating due to inadequate signage and lack of directions ("No sign directions from the traffic circle at Tshaneni to Mananga border post" - Sentiment score: -0.594). The state of the roads, including comments about potholes and general disrepair, were also a frequent complaint. These are correlated with other traffic management and environmental issues surfaced by visitors, with **problems including noise disturbance, traffic congestion, and environmental degradation** ("lot of littering especially around Nsoko, no littering bins" - Sentiment Score: -0.602).

   Visitors opined regularly on accommodations, pointing out digital connectivity and service quality ("Place of accommodation didn't deliver on wifi" - Sentiment score: -0.612). **Safety and security concerns were underscored by specific incidents** ("Phone stolen" - Sentiment Score: -0.749), a reminder of the impact that a single issue can have in the perception of a trip and of a destination. Resource availability was another regular concern, especially in terms of dining options and fuel ("No fuel at the petrol stations" - Sentiment score: -0.683), suggesting **difficulty in access to basic necessities while traveling.** There was also a gap in tourist information availability, not just in-country but in regional markets ("Advertise more in South Africa. People lack information about the tourist attractions in Eswatini." - Sentiment Score: -0.586).

   Similar to the discussion on how to interpret negative sentiment in comments about highlights, it is worth seeing the issues that were rated as having a positive sentiment to better understand the intent. Comments on the need for more promotions for wildlife ("More tourist information/pamphlets to guide the tourist to the country's interesting places" - Positive Sentiment Score: 0.644) suggest **an openness among tourists to explore more of what Eswatini has to offer and a positive view of the country's existing attractions and potential for more.**

International tour operators

In order to gain a better understanding of the destination's potential among international tour operators, a questionnaire was sent to them via the ETA's marketing department. A total of **38 international tour operators responded, 44.7%**

of whom were not yet selling the destination. The responses generally differed between the two groups, confirming the lack of knowledge of the destination for those not yet marketing it. Thus, the overall image of Eswatini is that of an unexplored country (28.9%) for the latter compared with a peaceful (25.8%) or hospitable (22.7%) destination for those selling the destination (generally as part of a trip to South Africa).

Table 21 – Overall image of Eswatini for international tour operators

Overall image of Eswatini	Selling Eswatini	Not selling Eswatini	Total
Adventure / off the beaten path	10.7%	13.7%	11.69%
Price level	4.9%	0.0%	3.25%
Natural heritage	11.7%	15.7%	12.99%
Overall image of Eswatini	**Selling Eswatini**	**Not selling Eswatini**	**Total**
Accessibility	3.9%	0.0%	2.60%
Community camps	3.9%	0.0%	2.60%
Cultural heritage	18.4%	15.7%	17.53%
Ethnic diversity	5.8%	5.9%	5.84%
Safaris/Rhinos	12.6%	7.8%	11.04%
I have no idea	0.0%	9.8%	3.25%
Hospitality	11.7%	9.8%	11.04%
Authenticity	13.6%	17.6%	14.94%
Remote lodges	2.9%	3.9%	3.25%
Other:	0.0%	0.0%	0.00%

Source: Survey.

There is also a difference in the **Unique Selling Proposition (USP)**, with **authenticity (17.6%)** as a first choice for the former and **cultural heritage (18.4%)** for those already selling Eswatini. The main reason why some operators do not offer the destination in their catalog is that they (70.6%) and their **customers (76.5%) do not really know the destination**. As a result, there is no demand (41.2%).

For those marketing the destination, **only 23.8% have a partnership with a Swati inbound operator,** the others working directly with South African operators (52.6%) or contracting hotels, lodges and other tourism service providers directly (15.9%). Although generally very satisfied (72.2%) with the services provided by their local or regional partners, **operators are nonetheless expecting more innovation in the creation and diversification of products (66.7%)**, as well as in the quality of existing products (40%). Although Eswatini is seen as a competitive destination in terms of price, some operators expect lower prices (46.7%). Generally speaking, however, **58.8% of respondents felt that the level of price competitiveness was above average** in terms of customer satisfaction. Similarly, the quality (64.7%) and variety of experiences (70.6%) are also considered above average by visitors.

The points of dissatisfaction are identical to those raised during interviews with local operators. The **issue of visas at borders and waiting times for entry by road** is frequently cited. The sometimes-low **level of standards and the lack of accommodation** are also recurrent points in the comments. Finally, a **lack of maintenance at tourist attractions and sites, issues with online booking for some activities and an insufficiently immersive experience** were seen as impeding factors for the destination to become more attractive. Interestingly, half of the operators marketing the destination are not looking for new products (52.6%), probably reflecting a lack of interest in extending the length of stay in the destination. This does not mean, however, that this lack of interest should be seen as an obstacle, given the comments made by those not marketing the destination.

Improving competitiveness requires different criteria depending on whether or not tour operators are familiar with the destination. Those already selling the destination are looking first and foremost for well-organized packages (16.67%) and more eco-lodges (18.33%), while the others are looking above all for more online information (15.63%).

Table 22 – International operators' needs for selling Eswatini

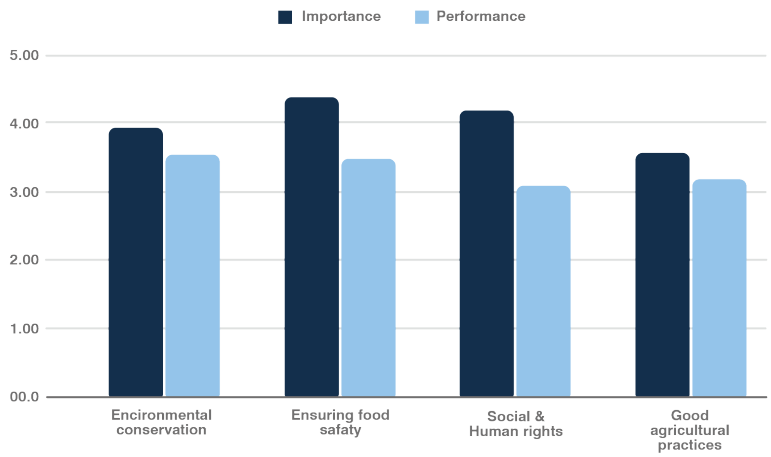
Categories	Selling	Not selling
Higher quality accommodations	10.00%	9.38%
More eco-lodges	18.33%	7.81%
More luxury dining opportunities	10.00%	4.69%
Higher end community products/services (including hygiene and cleanliness)	8.33%	4.69%
More special programmes for events / festivals	10.00%	6.25%
Well organized packages	16.67%	7.81%
Don't know the destination enough to answer	1.67%	12.50%
Need better/clearer information online about destination	8.33%	15.63%
Categories	**Selling**	**Not selling**
Have tourism information available in additional languages	6.67%	6.25%
Improve communication on safety, security and other important related information	5.00%	12.50%
Other:	5.00%	12.50%

Source: Survey

One very interesting result of the questionnaire is the fact that **tour operators who are not yet selling the destination are looking for packages with a longer stay than those currently operating in the country**. They are mainly looking for packages lasting 4 days or more (78.4%). 42.9% are even looking for packages lasting 7 days or more. In comparison, operators already present in the country are sticking to short-duration packages, with products lasting three days or less (55%). Everyone agrees that the destination has the potential to grow, but targeted campaigns are definitely needed in the destinations (see comments in annex). Operators also feel that they and their customers (90.3%) need to know more about the destination, and that limited accessibility (36.4%), including the visa issue, the lack of packages (30.3%) and the quality of products and services (30.3%), including the lack of immersive/authentic experiences, are the main reasons for not choosing the destination.

In conclusion, the main expectations of tourism operators for adding the destination to their catalog depend on ensuring food safety and hygiene for their customers (4.37/5), but also respect for social and human rights (4.16/5) ahead of environmental issues (3.92/5). Today, their perception is that **Eswatini does not yet seem to be meeting their expectations in terms of performance** (see figure below). In the comments provided, safety and hygiene are definitely key elements for any destination.

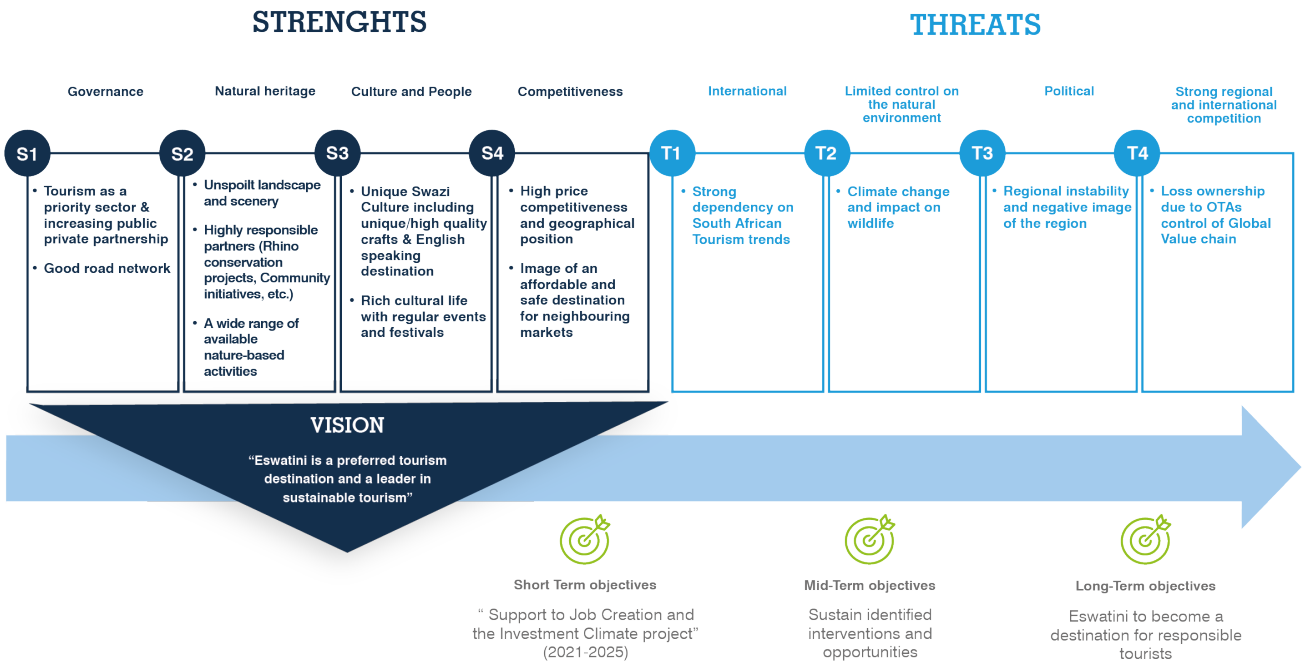
Figure 20 – Important items for selling a destination vs. Eswatini perceived performances



Summary of the situation analysis

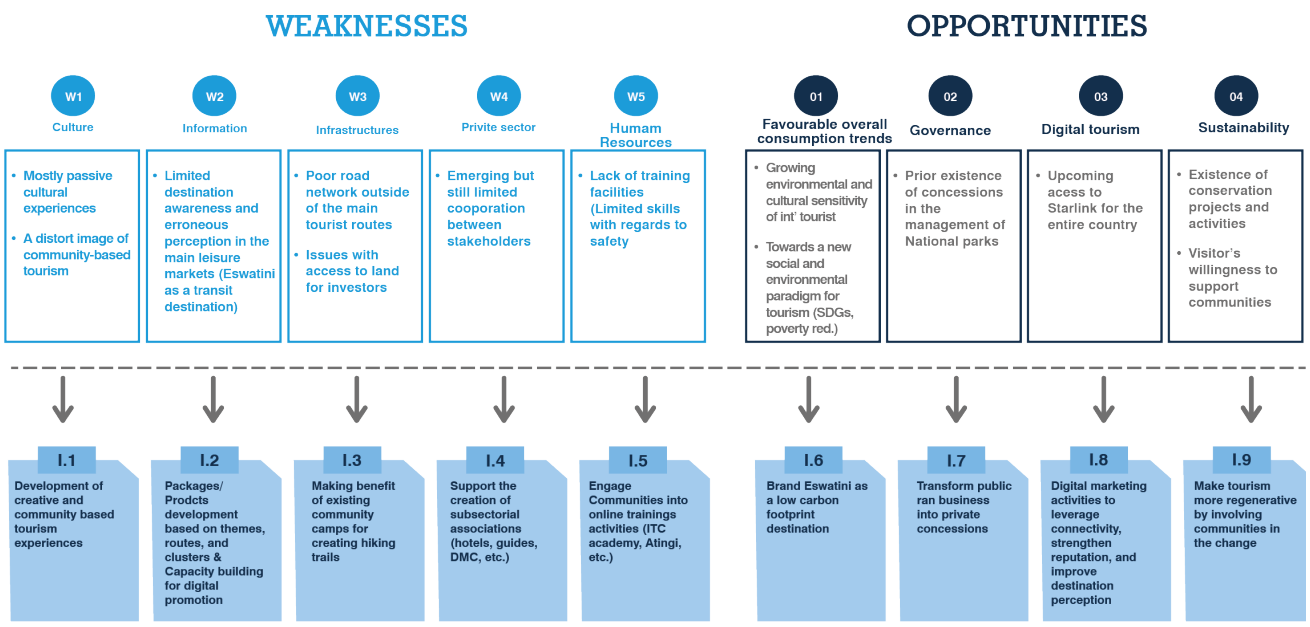
The analysis of the competitiveness of Eswatini's tourism offering is based on the project's objectives (*Encouraging growth and employment through product development and improved digital marketing*). Firstly, we present a review of the factors that led to the definition of the tourism sector's long-term objectives (vision) and, more specifically, the strengths on which to build. This also takes into account factors outside the sector, such as threats that are difficult to influence. This analysis takes up and develops the elements set out in this report in order to highlight the areas for improvement on which to build: both in terms of the sector's weaknesses and the opportunities arising from changes in the international tourism system and, more generally, the geopolitical and environmental conditions that today tend to have a strong influence on practices.

Figure 21 – Elements for building a vision of tourism in Eswatini



The strengths identified for the destination largely correspond to those considered essential to differentiate Eswatini from its competitors. In particular, these include the **uniqueness of its culture** and its high profile in terms of the many festivals organized throughout the year within a safe environment. The natural elements come into their own when it comes to wildlife. On the other hand, the **diversity of landscapes** over such short transport times is a real added value for the destination. Finally, Eswatini is considered by visitors and operators alike to be a **price-competitive destination.** Like all tourist destinations, Eswatini operates in a geopolitical and climate change environment over which it has no control. These threats have led the destination to adopt a sustainable tourism development approach to make the sector more resilient in the face of crises, however diverse they may be. Still with a view to sustainability, the country must also consider the dangers of its dependence on the South African market and online booking platforms.

Figure 22 – Elements for intervention identification



While the globalization of booking systems is also an opportunity, destinations need to work on their own digital promotion, and even more so on a digital marketing strategy. The participatory diagnosis carried out with the various stakeholders highlights a **confusion between promotion and marketing**, the former being an element of the latter. So, in addition to promotion, structuring and differentiation are marketing components. The **lack of tourist products or packages** is as much a question of international operators, selling or interested in selling the destination, as it is of a **fragmented offer** with little or no structure. This is due as much to a lack of coordination between stakeholders as to a perception of the destination as having no added value compared to neighboring destinations. What's more, the **"cultural experiences"** that are an asset for the destination tend to be passive and **not up to the standards** sought by today's leisure markets.

In addition, there is a demand from tourists to support schools and orphanages. Supporting orphanages may seem like a worthwhile thing to do, but an increasing body of evidence shows that it is harming the very children it tries to help. In fact, it fuels an industry where children are used as tourist attractions and, in some cases, trafficked and exploited. It is important for educating tourists to shift their support, whether volunteering or financial, to help organizations or programs that are enabling children to live in a family or to access education but in no case to visit them - **children are not tourist attractions!**

While there is a demand to share a moment in the life of local communities, today this is more in the context of a visit, of which schools and orphanages are a part, than an experience. Furthermore, the opportunities for local communities to benefit from the spin-offs of tourism are generally limited by **issues of accessibility** (the poor state of the road network apart from transit routes), a **misunderstanding of what community-based tourism is** (summed up in the creation of so-called "community" camps) or the **isolation of community projects from one another.** The lack of networking between tourism players and clusters, i.e. the structuring of the tourism offer to build experiences around a theme, and therefore market segments, is definitely a major weakness of the Eswatini destination. The forthcoming nationwide access to Starlink will certainly facilitate not only networking, but also the visibility of these networks and clusters.

As a result, the destination remains mainly **a transit destination** for international tourists or a safer weekend destination for tourists from neighboring countries. Of course, the development of tourism products requires an improvement in the quality of tourism services, which is currently limited by a **lack of training facilities**. Despite being a country where the vast majority of the population can speak English, the other international languages (French, German, etc.) are rarely, if ever, spoken. For example, the destination's promotional website is only in English, which severely limits the destination's visibility in leisure markets.

But the lack of products and activities can also be explained by the **issue of access to land** for national and international

investors. Eswatini has a dual land ownership system of freehold title and 'Swazi Nation Land', which is the result of a series of laws passed by colonial administrators between the early 1900s and 1968. The 2005 Constitution confers executive power for the management and governance of land in the Ngwenyama (the Siswati term for king) in trust for the nation. For many players, the issue of access to land remains complex and difficult to resolve. For many stakeholders, the issue of access to land remains complex and difficult to resolve. A system similar to that in Botswana, with the establishment of a land bank, is seen by some as an appropriate solution for defining priority tourism development areas and facilitating/ encouraging investment in the sector.

Finally, improving the competitiveness of the tourism offering is not just a question of improving its weaknesses, it is also a question of capitalizing on domestic or international models or trends. For example, the success of concession systems in certain national parks in Eswatini should encourage the replication of these systems for most for-profit projects managed today by parastatal agencies (e.g. ENTC). Because in essence, **public management of tourism enterprises is rarely profitable** (lack of specialists and capital). But also because it is difficult to form partnerships between these public companies and private companies (administrative processes, trust, etc.).

It is just as important to capitalize on these strengths as it is to capitalize on the opportunities offered by the market, particularly the growing demand for destinations that adopt responsible practices. Eswatini's small size provides an opportunity to develop slow-tourism and to **make Eswatini a "low carbon footprint destination"**.

5

A ROADMAP FOR ESWATINI TOURISM PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT AND COMPETITIVENESS

ENHANCING AND EXPANDING ESWATINI'S IMAGE 50

CHANGING THE MARKET MIX - TARGETING RESPONSIBLE TOURISTS 53
TOWARDS A PERFORMANCE-ORIENTED APPROACH 54

A ROADMAP FOR ESWATINI TOURISM PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT AND COMPETITIVENESS

Because there seems to be a confusion between promotion and marketing among the majority of players, it has been decided to structure the analytical approach in the same way as the definition of marketing, i.e. in three distinct and complementary categories (structuration, differentiation and promotion), each representing a marketing component.

The aim is to propose a step-by-step approach to the major areas for action identified. We obviously need :

(i) To change the destination's image while increasing its visibility and that of its stakeholders. This point is particularly relevant given the comments made by international tour operators that they and their customers have little knowledge of the destination.

(ii) To achieve this, we need to change or broaden the customer mix by developing new products or modifying existing ones with a CSR focus. Once again, observations drawn from surveys of international tour operators show that Eswatini is currently being marketed by operators who have little or no interest in extending the length of stay of their tours, whereas many are looking for new destinations and new products that include cultural and immersive experiences for stays of more than 4 days.

(iii) Finally, to adopt a performance monitoring and evaluation approach to ensure the sustainability of these actions and transform Eswatini and its range of products and services into a competitive destination in leisure markets.

Figure 23 - Summary of findings for improving destination marketing

	STRUCTURATION	DIFFERENTIATION	PROMOTION
Changing destination image	Unclear vs. defined linkages between sub-destinations	Slow mobility as a guiding principle	Approaching tourism as a network
Targeting responsible tourists	Passive vs. active cultural experiences	Unclear understanding of what sustainability means	Close vs. growth mindset
Performance oriented	Public Business vs. concessions	Sustainability= viability of business models	Digital presence vs. monitoring

The above figure provides a summary of these three levels of intervention as part of a marketing approach. It describes the main points of possible intervention, which will be detailed in the following subsections. An action plan and project sheets are provided in the appendix to explain in more detail how to implement the following recommendations.

Enhancing and expanding Eswatini's image

To grow and attract new international operators, Eswatini needs not only exist as a destination, including on the Internet, but also to differentiate itself from its regional and international competitors. Today, Eswatini has the means to differentiate itself as a safe, year-round destination, but also because its size enables it to offer low-carbon impact holidays, either on the basis of slow mobility or because of the short distances involved. While that differentiation in the short-term should not result in an expectation that Eswatini is the destination where travelers choose to land first, or that Eswatini is the only country they visit, Eswatini can become the triggering factor for a trip to the region.

Transform Eswatini into a year-round safe destination

Today, the seasonal nature of tourist flows is as much an obstacle to careers in the sector as it is to the development of local initiatives and therefore to the development of rural economies. Eswatini benefits from weekend visitors from neighboring countries and a large number of cultural events throughout the year. However, it does not attract tourists from the north during the period when they are looking for experiences in warmer climates. The destination needs to capitalize on its comparative advantages to try and remedy the phenomenon of seasonality while creating new opportunities.

To do this, **Eswatini can benefit from its rich wildlife, particularly a total of more than 500 bird species** - as many as the Kruger Park or a country like France. These bird species can be spotted across the country. **An increasing number of birdwatchers are traveling to long-haul destinations** to spot new birds that cannot be seen in their own country or region. There are three categories named Hard Core Birders, Enthusiastic Birders, and Casual Birders (Ecotourists). **In the U.K, birdwatching expenditures are estimated at $500 million per year.** This aligns with the findings in the market segmentation that there is potential for extending the length of stay for UK travelers by pursuing Mature Adventure and Wildlife Enthusiasts. Given their passion, many are willing to travel to remote and less-developed locations. As word spreads about birding in a new destination, the other two categories of birders, Enthusiasts and Casuals, who seek comforts usually associated with a more established destination, also begin to come. Those involved in **volunteer and bird tourism would be more off-season visitors for Eswatini** and they tend to be interested in sustainable tourism as well. The average birder is 50 years old, well-educated, and sustainably aware[5]. There is also a growing trend among bird tour operators to practice sustainable and socially responsible ecotourism which relies mainly on local goods and services and often involves supporting local conservation projects (regenerative tourism).

The second main opportunity for Eswatini to create opportunities during the off-season is to **capitalize on its living cultural heritage** and more particularly its living cultural events. While the argument of uncertain dates for certain events is valid, there is still room for maneuver if you are staying for a week or more, and it is possible to concentrate initially on events with more or less certain dates. These living cultural events are themes around which it is possible to **develop seasonal itineraries**. Today, the most famous are the Umhlanga (Reed Dance) held in August / September, the Incwala held in December / January and the Marula Festival in February-March. The country also hosts a number of sporting events throughout the year, in particular a series of challenging mountain bike races held in unique environments. Today there are extreme sports communities looking for unique adventures in safe environments.

It is precisely this secure environment that is Eswatini's strength in relation to its neighboring countries. There is an opportunity to **promote Eswatini as a safe MICE destination** in South African destinations. However, **the MICE tourism segment has not yet been exploited** by the destination. The construction of the Ezulwini International Conference Centre must be accompanied by a **strategy and a dedicated department for this market segment.**

Introduce slow mobility as a guiding principle

The slow tourism movement originated from the slow food movement. **Slow tourism promotes community, sustainability, and a deeper appreciation for the places** we visit with confidence. It also relates to low carbon footprint means of transportation. The transition to a slow mobility positioning opens up opportunities which are not only numerous but also clearly related to the overall perspective of the country's vision **"Eswatini is a preferred tourism destination and a leader in sustainable tourism."**

There are now many opportunities **to develop slow routes that combine nature and culture in complete safety.** Proposals have already been made for the northeastern part of the country with the Lubombo Eco Trails network[6]. But there are plenty of other possibilities, including the use of themes (crafts, gastronomy, untouched, community camps, adventure, nature, etc.). For these routes to be used in complete safety, **the installation of directional and information signs, the training of local guides (languages, animal biology, etc.) and the development of a network of contacts are essential.**

The first step is to link the products and experiences together **to offer visitors a journey through a themed Eswatini.** The means of transport then depends on the visitor's age and passions (hiking, biking, etc.). A number of operators already offer horse-riding tours, and the old railway line - now disused - can become both a historic and practical way to explore the country. Otherwise, short distances between accommodation can also be covered by motorized vehicles, depending

5 See https://www.cbi.eu/market-information/tourism/birdwatching-tourism/market-potential for tips and more info on The European market potential for birdwatching tourism.
6 https://indaloeswatini.wordpress.com

on the audience. The essential thing is the experience, as part of the definition of slow tourism.

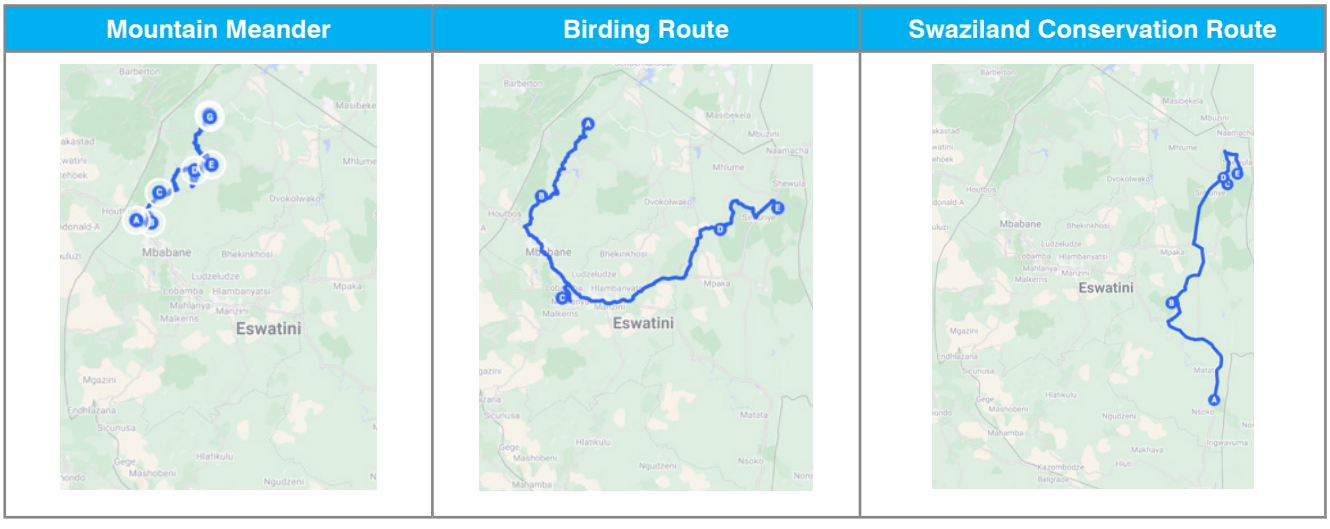
Approach tourism as a network

To enable slow mobility, tourism must be approached as a network of stakeholders, and these stakeholders must promote tourism in Eswatini with a single voice. There must be consistency in the shared vision of the destination. In particular, there needs to be ownership by everyone, including non-tourism stakeholders. The small size of the country also makes it possible to adopt a territorial marketing approach. This means a concept that deals with the territory as a product.

To position a territory as competitive, it must aim to attract, welcome, and retain the territorial users: investors, tourists and/or citizens. All must as well be involved in the promotion of the destination. However, **it requires branding work,** defining the type of the desired positioning, projecting an image of quality, and proclaiming a brand purpose. This work and its associated report acts as a first step in that perspective, in a sense that it sought to involve the entire tourism sector, both public and private.

This work need not start from scratch. Various efforts to begin this branding have already provided a foundation on how to increase the average length of stay while diversifying themes. This includes the work done by the then-Swaziland Tourism Authority's 2010 Swaziland Route Planner (with seven proposed routes - Mountain Meander, Valley of Heaven, Semi-Circular, Grand Valley, Birding, Secrets of Swaziland, Extreme Experiences, Cultural Encounters, Swaziland Conservation - each having descriptions but missing maps) and the current Eswatini Tourism Authority's Eswatini Brochure 2020 (with special focuses on Central Eswatini, North West Eswatini, North East Eswatini, South East Eswatini, and South West Eswatini). Likewise, there exist projects like Lubombo Eco Trails, already underway as a part of the GIZ-supported SADC-TFCA programme designed as "a network of existing and proposed trails set against the spectacular Lubombo Mountains[7]" that could be used as part of slow mobility and active tourism packages. For example, the new eco trail between the Goba community camp (Mozambique) and Mhlumeni Bush Camp could be extended as far as Shewula through the Mlawula Nature Reserve and the Mbuluzi Game Reserve, offering hikers or visitors several days in the heart of communities and nature. Given the different stakeholders involved - private tourism stakeholders and ETA, yes, but also local communities and the use of the Lubombo Transfrontier Conservation Area - it is important to have a coherent coordination among these projects in order to manage expectations, build a shared vision, and execute that vision in a sustainable way.

Figure 24 - 3 Example Maps Created from Swaziland Route Planner



Source: maps created by authors based on suggested routes from Swaziland Route Planner (2010)

For enhancing and expanding Eswatini's image, it is also necessary to consider reorganizing ETA website structure to make key content such as suggested itineraries and networks more accessible but also to introduce additional language options on Eswatini's tourism website. These additional languages will help increase the site's discoverability (discussed further in 7.3.1) as well as making the site more accessible and accommodating. Availability of information in the primary source-market languages about the destination (e.g. community experiences, itineraries, the ways it is working to be sustainable) can lead to more time spent on the site and a positive image of the destination, a necessary step to being more competitive with the targeted the independent and responsible tourists.

7 https://tfcaportal.org/lubombo-eco-trails-and-mhlumeni-goba-transboundary-trail

Changing the market mix - targeting responsible tourists

Being visible, communicating an image of a sustainable destination and offering themed itineraries is one thing, but the content is another. The diagnosis of the range of tourism goods and services on offer sometimes shows an incomplete or erroneous perception of what sustainability is. What's more, the experience offered to travelers is generally rather passive, far removed from the criteria of creative tourism or community immersion. It is therefore important to complete or clarify the sustainability criteria. This can be done as part of a participatory approach aimed at revitalizing the offer, so that tourism stakeholders become the driving force behind proposals.

Improve the general understanding of sustainability

It's important to get all the players on the same page when it comes to sustainability. This can be achieved through a regulatory approach or, more simply, by capacity building. The latter can be achieved through a variety of training courses, depending on the category of the stakeholders in the tourism value chain. But it is also possible to make available existing tools for self-training in good practice (ITC academy[8], Atingi[9]). For online training, it is encouraged to accompany learners in order to answer any questions or queries.

Such an approach can provide an introduction to certification schemes specific to the various players (GSTC criteria for destinations or operators[10], Travelife[11], etc.) as well as tools to support and assess their practices (RTA[12]).

Go from passive to active cultural & creative experiences with communities

Tourists already visit cultural or inhabited villages and attend shows, but often the experience is passive or too intrusive. Identifying these villages and studying the current offer would make it easier to set up a country-wide community tourism model with training for trainers. In this way, networking opportunities could be explored to complement the themed itineraries (crafts, community camps, etc.). The opportunity presented by community tourism is not only rural, and towns and townships in Mbabane or Manzini can also be involved.

These places represent the heart of the cities and one of the most disadvantaged populations. The term township tourism originated from South Africa whereby tourists interact with local residents. The city of Mbabane can be of great interest to foreign visitors, particularly those from Mozambique with regards to the use of Mbabane by political leaders during the Mozambique revolution.

Turn stakeholders into a source of ideas

The emulation observed during the diagnostic validation workshop, and more particularly during the tourism product and itinerary development exercises, should be encouraged to continue working with the inbound operators. The aim is to develop specialist operators and, within this framework, to work on their unique selling proposition by developing appropriate packages and itineraries.

8 https://learning.intracen.org/
9 https://www.atingi.org/
10 https://www.gstcouncil.org/gstc-criteria/
11 https://travelifesustainability.com/
12 https://www.be-rta.com/

Figure 25 – Proposal for new itineraries in Eswatini



Source: Authors

Towards a performance-oriented approach

As part of the drive to revitalize the tourism offering, it is important to carry out an analysis of projects in difficulty, including those managed by parastatal agencies and communities. An assessment of their business models and value propositions will enable them to better consider the best model to adopt to ensure their competitiveness. For private companies, their competitiveness also depends on the support offered by sector associations. A capacity-building component for the sectoral associations is therefore recommended to improve the nature of the public-private partnership needed for the sustainable development of tourism. All this is part of a performance-oriented approach, which also requires the adoption of a consistent approach to online performance monitoring.

Revitalize underperforming businesses

Although COVID is an important factor in the current difficulties encountered by certain companies or projects, the fact remains that, for the most part, these projects also require a rethink of their business model or even their ownership. Particularly, this concerns for-profit publicly and community owned entities.

- Generally speaking, public organizations are more bureaucratic with an absence of competitive pressure, and public managers have lower managerial autonomy and have weaker organizational commitment than their private sector counterparts.
- Community-owned initiatives business models lack transparency and strongly depend on public or donor fundings.

If agreement is reached with the entities concerned and the stakeholders, the under-performing companies identified could be asked to reassess their business model. This process involves identifying internal and external solutions with the aim of making the structure and business model more sustainable.

While the advantages linked to ownership or shareholding can be reviewed, it is generally necessary - in view of what has been observed in Eswatini - to also revisit / rejuvenate the offer of these structures to make it more immersive and comprehensive. Partnerships should also be envisaged as part of networking and the development of tourist itineraries. Once again, the tourism offer must be thought of as a journey and not as a succession of independent offers.

Reinforce the Public Private partnership

The Hospitality and Tourism Association of Eswatini (HOTAES), created in 1972, has today a close working relationship with the Eswatini Tourism Authority (ETA). However, the probable growth of tourism in Eswatini requires a structuring by sector of activity (e.g. hotels, tour operators, guiding, etc.) in order to facilitate the approach and efforts undertaken by this umbrella association. This means that each sub-sector should have its own association, making it easier to pass on information to a single umbrella body such as HOTAES. HOTAES can also set up committees to work on cross-cutting issues (accessibility, finance, competitiveness, safety, etc.) rather than sector-specific issues).

Adopt a consistent approach to online performance monitoring

Adopting a consistent approach to online performance monitoring helps lead toward sustained growth. Tracking of online performance allows us to discern which efforts are yielding positive outcomes and which are not meeting expectations. Embracing this dual focus enables us to allocate resources more effectively, doubling down on what works and phasing out less impactful strategies, an approach that demands active involvement from both public and private stakeholders. Their collaborative participation is key to enhancing the digital footprint of the destination, thereby improving its perception and, ultimately, its real-world standing.

Much of the online performance as it relates to Eswatini as a destination starts with www.thekingdomofeswatini.com, the primary source of information about the country provided by the Eswatini Tourism Authority. However, nearly all of these approaches apply to private stakeholders, too. Though there are instances where maintaining a static website is better than having no presence at all (e.g. for a small tourism entrepreneur who just needs to get the basics of their business online), **the tourism website's presence needs to be dynamic and regularly updated to give visitors the best possible experience.** User experience is crucial when it comes to the perception of the website and the country behind it. **Trip planning should be facilitated through an improved website navigation** and layout to help first-time site visitors make sense of the country, an improvement that can be monitored by how long target destinations stay on the site and how much they engage with the site. Likewise, these visits could have specific goals, or conversions, like number of maps downloaded (though all of the links in the 'Eswatini Map - 2019 Version' lead to deleted files). The need for accessible, updated maps is a priority. It's advisable to add internal links (ie. links from pages within the site to other pages within the site) to improve navigation and strengthen the site's performance in search engines.

From improving how visitors engage with the site, the next necessary step is to improve the site's discoverability to increase traffic of visitors from target markets. Given the stated interest in engaging with source markets that don't have English as primary language, including France, Germany, Mozambique, and the Netherlands, **it's important to translate the site into French, German, Portuguese, and Dutch.** This translation can lead to on-site performance gains, which were discussed earlier, as well as increasing the number of users who find the site. As a technical aside, translating the site means more than a quick plugin that does the translation for the user when they arrive on the site. This translation is done ahead of time and exists as part of the site and is accessible with direct links, enabling search engines like Google and Bing to catalog the site in those languages and send users looking for that information to that direct page. Supporting this discoverability of the site by non-English speaking markets, there should be a consideration for **a content strategy aimed at creating awareness and interest in new travelers.** The blog and guides for the site currently seem directed toward visitors who already know specifically about Eswatini. A strategy that includes more top-of-funnel, general interest content can help to position Eswatini for those searching for information about Southern Africa, wildlife, culture, etc.

As more visitors spend more time on www.thekingdomofeswatini.com and planning their trips to Eswatini, they will soon find themselves interacting with Eswatini's tourism sector, either through their proprietary websites and social media profiles, or through platforms like TripAdvisor. This means they'll encounter what other travelers have shared previously about their experiences. In order to enhance Eswatini's image as a destination, **public and private stakeholders need to become proactive about reputation management**. Travelers find user-generated content like reviews more trustworthy than official brand-produced content, so it's important to handle all reviews, positive and negative, with care. This starts by promoting and facilitating the importance of responding to reviews and feedback from online platforms. In many cases, Eswatini's most popular attractions aren't "claimed" on TripAdvisor, **meaning businesses and organizations across the tourism sector are not taking responsibility for nor managing their online reputation.** This step, and how to regularly review these platforms and evaluate their performance (e.g. rate of positive reviews year-over-year) should then be covered in stakeholder training to ensure a higher level of engagement and response with reviews. More than just reading and reacting online, this training should also cover how to monitor performance over time to make sure problematic themes are not recurring. The more this is an industry-wide effort, the more it will help to strengthen Eswatini's image.

Online performance monitoring is not just connected with improving the destination's perception for travelers. It's also about **strengthening the sector through developing and maintaining online resources for Eswatini's tourism stakeholders.** This includes ensuring that existing training offers are updated and accessible, and that training now done through industry partners is easily findable. It's also possible to use incentives to motivate stakeholders to improve themselves and to promote best practices, which could be accomplished by relaunching the Eswatini Tourism Excellence Awards.

6

ACTION PLAN

ACTION PLAN

Strategies	Strategic activities	Recommended actions	How?	Level of priority (1 to 3)	Leading implementing partners
Enhancing and expanding Eswatini's image	Transform Eswatini into a year-round safe destination	Target off-season niche markets	▪ Entering the European market for birdwatching ▪ Develop packages around selected events and volunteer tourism	2	ETA, Department of Forestry, ENTC
		Promote Eswatini as a safe MICE destination in South African destinations	▪ Develop a MICE strategy (including the creation	3	ETA
	Introduce slow mobility as a guiding principle	Develop routes and itineraries for slow mobility (horse riding, hiking, biking, etc.)	▪ Identify and select itineraries all around the country with different themes (nature, communities, adventure, crafts, gastronomy, etc.) ▪ Develop and install signages along selected itineraries ▪ Train and certify nature local guides	1	ETA, ENTC
	Approach tourism as a network	Promote the destination with a single voice	▪ Adopt a territorial marketing approach (branding exercise) ▪ Consider reorganizing ETA website structure to make key content such as suggested itineraries and networks more accessible ▪ Introducing additional language options on Eswatini's tourism website	1	ETA
Changing the market mix - targeting responsible tourists	Go from passive to active cultural & creative experiences with communities	Develop CBT experiences in pre-existing communities, with objective to create network	▪ Identify existing villages/ communities often visited by tourists in order to assess the level of immersion and the need to redesign the experience ▪ Evaluate potential routes to link communities between each other based on themes (crafts, community camps) ▪ Undertake CBT facilitation trainings in townships (urban tours) and rural communities	1	ETA, Municipalities
	Improve the general understanding of sustainability	Engage tourism stakeholders into trainings on sustainability	▪ Promote and facilitate the use of existing online tools for self-training (ITC academy, Atingi, RTA) ▪ Engage stakeholders into sustainability in-person trainings	2	ETA, ICT Department
	Turn stakeholders into a source of ideas	Engage tourism stakeholders into package development	▪ Reiterate workshops and training on package development with a view of specializing inbound operators into specific niche markets ▪ Engage artisans into the development of creative tourism experiences	2	ETA

Towards a performance-oriented approach	Revitalize underperforming businesses	Revise the business model and/or ownership of underperforming public and community for-profit projects	▪ Study business models of projects ▪ Propose guidelines and steps for revision ▪ Proceed with revision if agreed	3	Ministry of tourism and Environment
		Revisit the offer of underperforming public and community for-profit projects	▪ Analyze projects value proposition ▪ Develop rejuvenation strategy ▪ Proceed with training of team	3	
	Reinforce the Public Private partnership	Strengthen sectoral associations	▪ Propose a technical support to sectoral associations for their structuration ▪ Study the terms of references and objectives of sectoral associations ▪ Proceed with participative workshop to create or consolidate associations ▪ Identify activities for sectoral associations based on objectives (education, communication, advocacy) + build business models for activities to take place	3	ETA, MSME Department
	Adopt a consistent approach to online performance monitoring	Enhance user experience	▪ Improve website navigation and layout to facilitate trip planning ▪ Update maps and make available for download ▪ Develop internal linking strategy to improve navigation ▪ Periodic checks for broken links or 404 pages	1	ETA
		Increase discoverability	▪ Translate site into French, German, Dutch, and Portuguese ▪ Content strategy aimed at creating awareness and interest in new travelers	1	ETA
		Reputation management	▪ Promote and facilitate use of responding to and incorporating reviews and feedback from online platforms (e.g. Tripadvisor) ▪ Engage public and private stakeholders in trainings	3	ETA
		Develop and maintain online resources for tourism stakeholders	▪ Relaunch tour guides course and/or update information with relationship HOTAES ▪ Ensure ETA resources page is up to date ▪ Consider relaunching Eswatini Tourism Excellence Awards (last done in 2020) to promote best practices	3	ETA

7

PROJECT SHEETS

PROJECT SHEETS

Action sheet 1 - Transform Eswatini into a year-round safe destination

Title of strategic activity « Transform Eswatini into a year-round safe destination»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s), ETA

Objectives and expected results

The main objective of this intervention is to transform Eswatini into a year-round safe destination by

- Targeting off-season niche markets
- Promoting Eswatini as a safe MICE destination in South African destinations

Activities

- **Activity 1** – Entering the European market for birdwatching
  - Develop terms of references for hiring a birdwatching specialist with the objective to:
    - Undertake a competitiveness analysis by region
    - Benchmark Eswatini for birdwatching against its main competitors in Africa
    - Design itineraries and products
    - Identify youth from local communities to be trained on birdwatching guiding
    - Develop a marketing strategy for this market segment
  - Proceed with preliminary trainings amongst youths in remote communities using local knowledge of wildlife as an asset
  - Identify and train inbound operators interested in selling birdwatching products
- **Activity 2** – Develop packages around cultural events
  - Select events to be promoted within a participatory process
  - Create thematic itineraries around each event
  - Train local communities in thematic experiences
  - Price services and packages associated with events
  - Promote packages online (create a space for events and packages on ETA website)

    NB: *The limits of the commercial exploitation of cultural events also need to be discussed with local communities*
- **Activity 3** – Develop a MICE strategy
  - Create a MICE department inside ETA (Amendment of ETA act)
  - Undertake a Market study for MICE (including a business model for MICE in Eswatini)
  - Develop an offer for MICE in Eswatini including a prioritization of target population
  - Create a space for MICE in ETA website

Administrative and financial provisions:

- Birdwatching Expert (10 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up)
- Cultural events /product development expert (10 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up)
- MICE expert (10 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up)
- Training of youths in remote communities (Department of wildlife and/or bird watching expert)
- Miscellaneous (water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)
- Website update/upgrade

Action sheet 2 - «Introduce slow mobility as a guiding principle»

Title of strategic activity «Introduce slow mobility as a guiding principle»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s), ETA

Objectives and expected results

The main objective of this intervention is to transform Eswatini into a low carbon footprint destination by developing routes and itineraries for slow mobility (horse riding, hiking, biking, etc.)

Activities

- **Activity 1** – Identify and select itineraries all around the country with different themes (nature, communities, adventure, crafts, gastronomy, etc.)
  - Animate a workshop with inbound operators for the identification of unique themes and associated itineraries
  - Study the feasibility of pre-selected itineraries
  - Identify and cost training and infrastructure needs
  - Propose a priority list of itineraries (based on feasibility / sustainability / competitiveness)
- **Activity 2** – Develop and install signages along selected itineraries
  - Select local materials for the construction of eco-friendly long-life signage options
  - Identify local artisans (through tender)
  - Select local artisans based on price and CSR practices
  - Build signage posts
  - Associate local guides and communities into the installation of signages
- **Activity 3** –Train and certify local nature guides
  - Create a pool of nature guides along itineraries
  - Train nature guides (along itineraries)
  - Certify nature guides

Administrative and financial provisions:

- Product/itineraries development international and local experts (10 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up for international) - ex: hiking, biking, horse riding local experts to ensure feasibility (technical, practical, etc.)
- Training of youths in remote communities (Department of wildlife and/or experts)
- Miscellaneous (water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)
- Website update/upgrade

Action sheet 3 - «Approach tourism as a network»

Title of strategic activity « Approach tourism as a network»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s), ETA

Objectives and expected results

The main objective of this intervention is to consolidate the structuration of the tourism supply side especially through the adoption of a common brand as well as in improving the promotion of strategic activities aiming at enhancing and expanding Eswatini's image

Activities

- **Activity 1** – Invest into a policy of image, differentiation and valorisation
  - Use of sentiment analysis and of a participatory process with tourism stakeholders to define Eswatini's identity to give meaning and value to a brand - (Content created by any brand is perceived as less authentic than content created by users!)
  - Carry out diagnostics to better define Eswatini marketing positioning.
  - From logo to brand platform: building an identity for Eswatini
  - Making the brand live over time
- **Activity 2** – Consider reorganizing ETA website structure
  - Make key content such as suggested itineraries and networks (community camps, artisans, responsible operators, etc.) more accessible
  - Include more visitor-generated content (86% of people became interested in a particular destination after seeing photos of other users holidaying in that location)
- **Activity 3** – Introducing additional language options on Eswatini's tourism website
  - Align languages options to targeted market segments

Administrative and financial provisions:

- Digital marketing expert (20 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up) including training of marketing team on sentiment analysis
- Workshop on territorial marketing (room rental, food, etc.)
- Miscellaneous (water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)
- Website update/upgrade

Action sheet 4 - «Go from passive to active cultural & creative experiences with communities»

Title of strategic activity «Community based tourism facilitation»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s)

Objectives and expected results

The main objective of this intervention is to develop or reinforce CBT experiences in communities already visited by tourists, with the objective to create network or CBT experiences. This should be done through the use of ITC's CBT facilitation manual (Consider, Conceive, Craft, Connect, Conserve)

Activities

- **Activity 1** – Identify existing villages/communities often visited by tourists
  - Survey among tourism stakeholders villages often visited by tourists
  - List villages
  - Visit selected villages and the Mbabane's township in order to evaluate the likelihood for each visited community to become a learning center (sensitivity, management and cooperation, experience with tourists, etc.)
  - For the selected communities (a maximum of three), assess the level of immersion and the need to redesign the experience
- **Activity 2** – Undertake a CBT strategy
  - Evaluate potential routes to link communities between each other based on themes (crafts, community camps)
  - Identify the opportunity for clusters development based on theme (visit communities, assess quality and potential for creative tourism experiences
  - Create a network of CBT initiatives
- **Activity 3** – Undertake CBT facilitation trainings in selected rural community and at least in one township in Mbabane (urban tours) - This includes to structure and boost ecotourism tours with young local guides to showcase the natural and cultural aspects of the resident communities

Administrative and financial provisions:

- Tourism product development and junior CBT experts
  - Senior product development expert (20 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up)
  - Junior CBT experts (60 days in Eswatini)
- Food for trained communities
- Communication materials
- Miscellaneous (water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)
- Website update/upgrade

Action sheet 5 - «Improve the general understanding of sustainability»

Title of strategic activity «Improving general understanding and practices in terms of sustainability»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s), ETA

Objectives and expected results

The main objective of this intervention is to engage tourism stakeholders into trainings and self-trainings on sustainability in order to build more responsible operators able to educate their customers as well on good practices

Activities

- **Activity 1** – Promote and facilitate the use of existing online tools for self-training (ITC academy, Atingi, RTA, etc.)
  - Engage with existing online platforms to set up specific trainings on sustainability in tourism
  - Conducting three interactive webinar sessions (1,5 hours each) with ca. 20-40 participants including facilitating discussions and providing opportunities for peer exchange and reflection based on an existing blended learning concept.
  - Supporting the participants during self-directed learning, providing regular checkups and reminders, answering individual questions as well as pointing participants to existing additional materials if needed
  - Encouraging, monitoring and moderating forum activities of the course participants
  - Support the general promotion of the programme and develop strategies to promote the programme
- **Activity 2** – Engage stakeholders into sustainability in-person trainings
  - Develop curriculums for each category of stakeholders for in-person training on sustainability (Inbound operators and local guides, Hotels, Restaurants, communities, etc.)
  - Organize three days training sessions for each categories of stakeholders
  - Develop code of conducts for each category of stakeholders with regard to sustainability practices

Administrative and financial provisions:

- Sustainable tourism expert (10 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up) - for the online trainings
- Sustainable tourism expert(s) (5 days in Eswatini +10 days preparation and follow-up) - it is recommended to associate in-person and online trainings for one expert to compensate carbon footprint
- Communication materials
- Miscellaneous (conference room rental, water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)

Action sheet 6 - «Turn stakeholders into a source of ideas»

Title of strategic activity «Turn stakeholders into a source of ideas»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s)

Objectives and expected results

The main objective of this intervention is to engage tourism stakeholders into package development. This includes the sharing of new products and creative / immersive tourism experiences. It aims to benefit from the stakeholders' knowledge of their territories to improve the spread of social and economic benefits to the overall territory.

Activities

- **Activity 1** – Reiterate workshops and training on package development with a view of specializing inbound operators into specific niche markets
    - Selection of inbound operators by niche markets
    - Coaching and capacity building
        - USP and packages development through participatory process
        - Training and sharing knowledge on sources markets
        - Access to market facilitation (B2B)

  Nb: *Assess whether all tourism assets can be visited without detrimental effects on the biodiversity and local communities. The limits of visiting these areas need to be determined – how many visitors, how many vehicles, etc.*
- **Activity 2** – Engage artisans into the development of creative tourism experiences
    - Identify rural crafts communities
    - Define potential creative experiences
    - Design selected creative experiences
    - Develop access to market (locally with selling point and through linkages to packages and inbound operators)
    - Create a crowdfunding platform for supporting community initiatives

Administrative and financial provisions:

These activities can be linked to Action 4

- Product development & tourism expert (10 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up) - for the online trainings
- Marketing expert (remote support with one trip to Eswatini) (10 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up)
- Communication materials
- Miscellaneous (conference room rental, water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)

Action sheet 7 - «Revitalize underperforming businesses»

Title of strategic activity «Revitalize underperforming businesses»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s), Ministry of tourism and Environment

Objectives and expected results

The main objective of this intervention is (i) to revise the business model and/or ownership of underperforming public and community for-profit projects and (ii) to revisit the offer of underperforming public and community for-profit projects for increasing their attractiveness and competitiveness.

Activities - These activities are related to each other and this strategic activity should only be completed if the activity 3 is agreed by the concerned entities

- **Activity 1** – Study business models and value proposition of projects
  - Identify and agree with Ministry of Tourism and environment on projects to be revised including those managed by ENTC
  - Collect financial and management process information
  - Analysis of business model (delivery of a report for each studied projects)
- **Activity 2** – Propose guidelines and steps for revision
  - Prepare a PPT presentation of analyzed business models including a concept note for proposed directions for the projects (which are the expected changes):
    - Ownership & Partnerships
    - Management & human resources
    - Value proposition
- **Activity 3** – Proceed with revision of business model if agreed
  - Good practice and market access principles need to be introduced, including the role of digital in raising the profile of tourism products.
  - Develop in a participatory manner
    - A new value proposition and a revised business model for each selected project
    - Activities to be proposed (including through partnership with other public or private entities - Tourism as a network) - This includes a pricing and costing exercise
- **Activity 4** – Develop rejuvenation strategy for products and services
  - Discuss the causes of failures for projects
  - Discuss ways and human resources to implement new proposed activities
    - Ensuring the quality, improving product & service
    - Innovation in products
    - Increasing productivity and reducing costs : cooperation
  - Train teams or communities in all aspect of business management (use of online tools when possible)
    - Maintenance
    - Guiding and services supply
    - Accounting and Booking
    - Access to market

Administrative and financial provisions:

- Tourism economist and product development specialist (15 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up) - for the online trainings
- Miscellaneous (conference room rental, water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)

Action sheet 8 - «Reinforce the public-private partnership»

Title of strategic activity «Reinforce the public-private partnership»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s), ETA

Objectives and expected results

The main objective of this intervention is to strengthen sector associations in order to improve dialogue between government and private stakeholders and to better engage with the principles of shared governance (a prerequisite for the application of sustainability principles).

Activities

- **Activity 1** - Propose a technical support to sectoral association for their structuration
  - Draft the conditions of a technical support for sector association
  - Contact of existing sector associations
  - Contact of individuals and stakeholders in sector without sector association
  - Discuss the interest, objectives and activities to support a sector association
- **Activity 2** - Study the terms of references and objectives of sectoral association
  - Collect terms of references
  - Benchmark TOR, activities and objectives of interested association
  - Prepare a strategic proposal to revise and/or support sector association development including a plan to transform HOTAES into a confederation based on the model of Madagascar
- **Activity 3** - Proceed with participative workshops to create or consolidate associations
  - Share strategic proposal for each association
  - Validate new terms of reference
- **Activity 4** - Identify activities for sectoral association based on objectives (education, communication, advocacy) + build business models for activities to take place
  - Develop one project proposal for each association related to education, communication or advocacy - including budget and implementation plan

Administrative and financial provisions:

- Tourism or association expert (10 days in Eswatini + 15 days of preparation and follow up) - for the online trainings
- Miscellaneous (conference room rental, water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)

Action sheet 9 - «Adopt a consistent approach to online performance monitoring»

Title of strategic activity «Adopt a consistent approach to online performance monitoring»

Human resources and leading implementation agency : Expert(s), ETA

Objectives and expected results

The main objectives of this intervention are to strengthen Eswatini's tourism presence online and build capacity for both the public and private sector through training on digital marketing and monitoring aimed at increasing visibility and competitiveness of products and services.

Activities

- **Activity 1** - Enhance the user experience
  - Improve website navigation and layout to facilitate trip planning
  - Incorporate package development from Action 6 to update maps, make available for download
  - Develop and implement internal linking strategy to facilitate navigation
  - Create system and assign responsible party to periodically check for broken links or 404 pages
- **Activity 2** - Increase discoverability of ETA website
  - Create site map and text document with links to all to-be translated pages
  - With use of tools (DeepL, AI), create first draft of translations into French, German, Dutch, and Portuguese
  - Have texts reviewed for clarity
  - Develop content strategy aimed at creating awareness and interest in new travelers featuring mix of top-level and long-tail keywords
  - Implement plan and assign responsible party for regular content creation
- **Activity 3** - Reputation management
  - Promote and facilitate use of responding to and incorporating reviews and feedback from online platforms (e.g. Tripadvisor)
  - Engage public and private stakeholders in 1 kickoff in-person training, then quarterly online meeting to check progress and implement online monitoring (e.g. check recurring themes)
- **Activity 4** - Develop and maintain online resources for tourism stakeholders
  - Relaunch tour guides course and/or update information on with relationship to HOTAES' training
  - Ensure ETA resources page is up to date
  - Relaunch Eswatini Tourism Excellence Awards (last done in 2020) to promote best practices

Administrative and financial provisions:

- Digital marketing expert (10 days in Eswatini + 10 days of preparation and follow up) for content strategy and training
- Agency or user experience expert (5 days - remote) for proposal on website improvements
- Translator(s) with experience in French, German, Dutch, and Portuguese to review AI translated texts for clarity (3 days per language - remote)
- Miscellaneous (conference room rental, water, coffee break, presentation tools, transportation)

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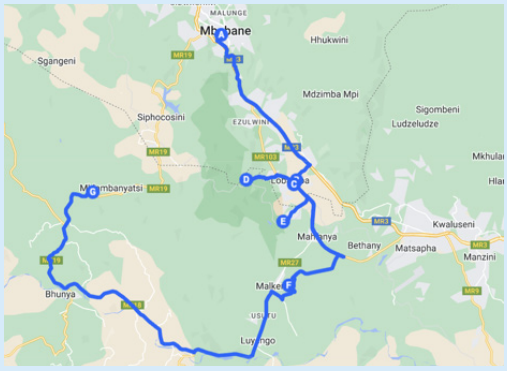
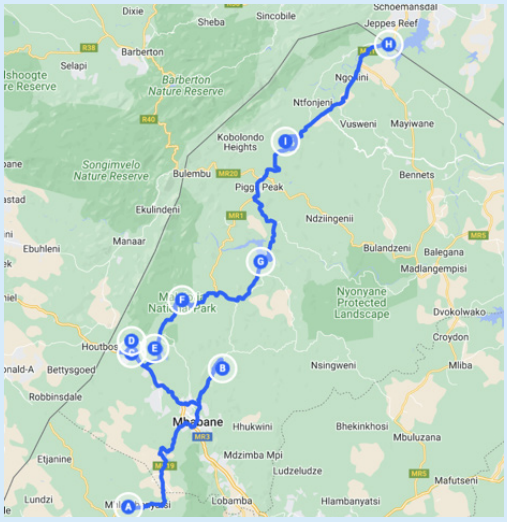
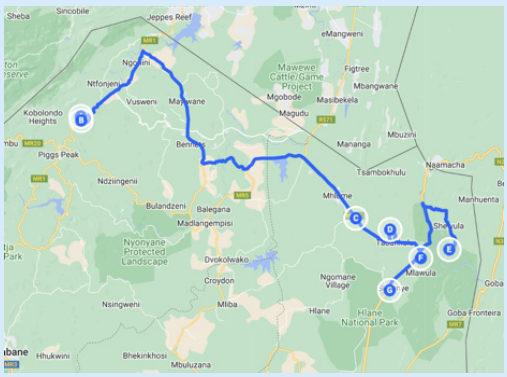
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ANNEX

ANNEX

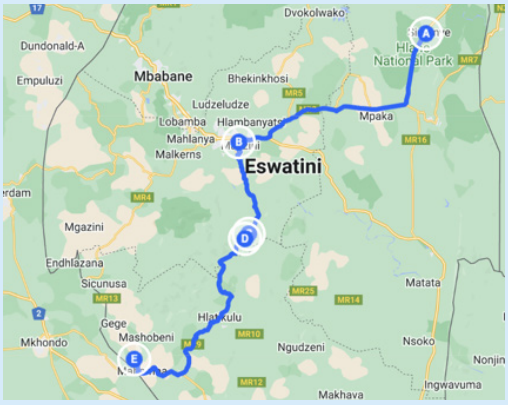
Annex 1 - Itinerary & Meetings

This itinerary was undertaken from Wednesday, February 14, 2024 through Sunday, February 18, 2024.

Schedule	Route
Day 1 • Swaziland National Museum • King Sobhuza II Memorial Park • Mantenga Cultural Village • Mlilwane Wildlife Sanctuary • Malandelas Lifestyle • Swazi Candles Centre • Forester Arms	
Day 2 • Sibebe Resort • Ngwenya Glass Factory • Ngwenya Mine • Hawane Resort • Malolotja Nature Reserve • Maguga Lodge • Lake Matsamo Community Project • Phophonyane Lodge	
Day 3 • Piggs Peak Hotel • Vuvulane Food Market • Sugarcane Museum • Tambankulu Guest House • Shewula Mountain camp • Mbuluzi Game Reserve and Lodges • Simunye Country Club	

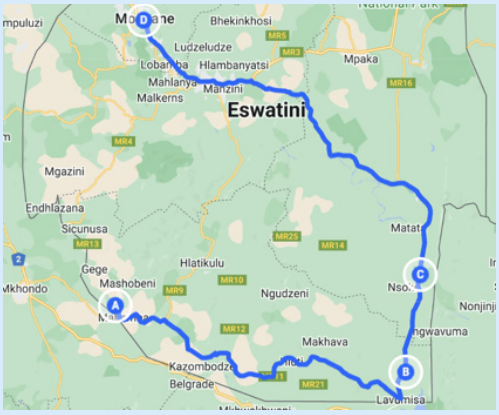
Day 4

- Old Stone Church Museum
- Manzini Market
- Olive Country Lodge
- Tfutjana Mount Resort and Caving
- Mahamba Gorge Lodge



Day 5

- Royal Jozini
- Kamsholo Bushveld Safaris



The following meetings were held on Monday, February 12th and Tuesday, February 13th:

Monday, February 12th

- **08:30** - ETA (HODs and Research team)
- **10:00** - Ministry of Tourism & Environmental Affairs (Principal Secretary, Director-Tourism, Senior Tourism Officer)
- **11:00** - Tour Operators (Inbound & Outbound: Melula Travel, Total Experience, Calf Tours, Amahle Tours)
- **12h00** - Hospitality and Tourism Association of Eswatini (HOTAES) Executive
- **14h00** - Ministry of Commerce, Industry & Trade: Director MSME, Director International Trade Eswatini Investment & Trade Promotion Authority: Executive Manager Investment Promotion, Executive Manager Trade & Promotion Small Enterprises Development Company: Chief Executive Officer, Senior Manager Strategy & Organisational Performance
- **15h15** - Ministry of Information, Communication and Technology: Director Communications, Director Information & Media
- **16h00** - Municipal Council of Mbabane: Chief Executive Officer, HOD Local Economic Development

Tuesday, February 13th

- **08h30** - Ezulwini Municipality: Acting Chief Executive Officer, Town Planner
- **10h00** - Eswatini National Trust Commission: Chief Executive Officer, Director Parks, Director, Conservation, Transfrontier Conservation Areas and Boundless Africa
- **12h30** - Lunch at Summerfield Botanical Garden
- **14h00** - Municipal Council of Manzini: Head of Strategy, Marketing and Communications
- **15h00** - Royal Eswatini National Airways Corporation: Director Commercial, Marketing and Communications Manager, Pricing and Revenue Manager
- **16h00** - Eswatini Aviation Civil Authority: Director Airport, Airport City Planner and Marketing & Communication Manager

Annex 2 - Exist Survey Responses

In the 2023 Exit Survey, visitors had the option to select from a list of multiple-choice options, as well as input their own. Below are the multiple-choice options from each section of the survey.

Perceptions	Highlights	Issues
▫ Unsafe Country	▫ No highlights	▫ No complaints
▫ High HIV rate	▫ Friendly people	▫ Improve road infrastructure
▫ Good customer service	▫ Scenic beauty	▫ Improve road signage
▫ Nice weather	▫ Cultural heritage	▫ Road tax
▫ Poor internet	▫ Food	▫ Establish more information offices
▫ Good roads	▫ Safety	▫ Littering
▫ Racist people	▫ Cleanliness	▫ Improve border services
▫ Unfriendly people	▫ Green country	▫ Removal of stray animals
▫ Landlocked country	▫ Wildlife	▫ Improve international banking facilities
▫ Poor infrastructure	▫ Nice weather conditions	▫ Focus on poverty alleviation
▫ Beautiful scenery	▫ Good country	▫ High Rate of HIV/AIDS Pandemic
▫ Plenty of wildlife	▫ Peace and stability	▫ Traffic police are harsh
▫ Clean	▫ Good road infrastructure	▫ Internationally Advertise SD
▫ Safe	▫ Incwala	▫ Improve Border Post Building Structures
▫ Beautiful culture	▫ Reed dance	▫ Extend Border Working Hours
▫ Kingdom	▫ Bush fire	▫ Poor Quality Accomodation than expected
▫ Small	▫ Respectful people	▫ Bad Customer Services
▫ Poor roads	▫ Good infrastructure	▫ Poor weather
▫ Friendly people	▫ Good accommodation	▫ Dangerous driving
▫ Poor country	▫ Good customer service	▫ Poor network access
▫ Developing country		▫ Expensive data
▫ Peaceful		▫ No public transport options

Annex 3 - Tour operators survey responses

Why and how does Eswatini have the potential to grow as a tourism destination?

- New destination for our market
- Improved smaller, more boutique options with strong personalized cultural offerings. would help.
- Need to share and promotion on social network more newsletter
- If you develop and market an USP, there is definitely a potential to keep the tourists traveling through Eswatini from Kruger to KZN for some more days in the country.
- I don't know enough
- Just remove visa application and make it a visa free destination
- People are looking for new destinations
- A unique Destination with own culture and nice and friendly people
- There are many niche travel markets that would be attracted to Eswatini if the available products aligned with desires. 'Country counters', 'festival visitors', 'music junkees', 'sports travelers', 'agricultural tourism' etc. Even 10,000 extra overnight visitors a year would have a tremendous impact on the country's economy.
- New locations and destinations in Southern Africa are in high demand and opening up Eswatini could be very beneficial to all
- Implement e-visa or visa on arrival for countries with larger population like India
- Southern Africa is a very attractive part of the world with wonderful opportunities, culture, ethnic diversity, wildlife and delightful people, but Eswatini has to be marketed and promoted professionally
- Think there should be a bit more presence on the market
- One of the very few unknown and undiscovered destinations
- It's a small country with beautiful scenery wish does attract clients .fix the roads to Mantenga cultural village and other places of interest
- Unfortunately, we do not have an advertising campaign on Swaziland in France .
- It is close both to Mozambique and South Africa, it can offer a deeply African yet unique experience. If the prices are good, and the promotion is satisfactory, the rise in visits is likely.
- People still want to travel, also to less known destinations
- There is an opportunity for Eswatini to market itself as the safe destination which it is. There is potential to get the Mozambican market to go to Eswatini for shopping and tourism. Mpumalanga has proven to be unsafe for Mozambican registered vehicles crossing over and many Mozambicans are no longer going there.
- The demand for travel has grown, so as long as a destination promotes, the travel to the destination will grow
- The history and culture of Eswatini has everything to attract tourists from all over the world.
- Its location within a country receiving such a huge number of visitors should allow Eswatini to easily attract a nice number of them to visit the country.
- We can do so many things and it's different that SA and Moz
- Both for cultural and wildlife experiences, I believe it has very good potential
- Easier access would improve tourism numbers. At the moment you have to self drive which clients are not always happy to do.
- I think it can be a beautiful add on to a South Africa program.
- Part of the appeal of Eswatini is that it is not too busy but tourism can be increased - it would be good to ensure this is well managed though, so that the remote and unique feel is not lost
- There is great potential as more international travelers become aware of the destination
- It is a beautiful country with amazing people and you should develop different areas further to explore the country and have tourists want to spend more than 1 or 2 nights, but even up to 5 or 6 nights.
- Little UK Travel Trade exposure & promotion currently.
- With more awareness and publicity, visitor numbers are likely to increase.

Annex 4 - Sentiment Analysis

To Stay - Accommodations

Accommodation	Most Recent - English	Most Recent - Any Language	# of Mgmt. Responses of Most Recent 10 Reviews
Summerfield Botanical Garden	February 2024	February 2024	0/10
Foresters Arms	March 2023	January 2024 [Dutch]	0/10
Royal Swazi Spa*	January 2020	March 2020 [Dutch]	9/10
Piggs Peak Hotel & Casino	February 2024	February 2024	0/10
Mantenga Lodge	February 2024	February 2024	0/10
The George Hotel	June 2022	February 2024 [French]	4/10
Hilton Garden Inn Mbabane	February 2024	February 2024	10/10
The Royal Villas	June 2023	June 2023	6/10
Happy Valley Hotel Ezulwini	February 2024	February 2024	0/10
Mountain View International Hotel by BON Hotels	November 2023	November 2023	3/10

*Currently closed, but this is not reflected on TripAdvisor, Agoda, etc. On Facebook, a 2021 post says it's in liquidation.

To Do - Activities

Activity	Most Recent - English	Most Recent - Any Language	# of Mgmt. Responses of Most Recent 10 Reviews
Swazi Cultural Village	November 2023	November 2023	0/10
Hlane Royal National Park	January 2024	January 2024	0/10
Mlilwane Wildlife Sanctuary	March 2023	October 2023 [French]	0/10
Mantenga Nature Reserve	November 2022	January 2024 [Dutch]	0/10
Traditional Swazi Craft Markets	November 2022	November 2022	0/10
Malolotja Nature Reserve	July 2022	July 2022	0/10
Mbuluzi Game Reserve and Lodges	April 2021	April 2021	3/10
Sibebe Rock	July 2022	February 2024 [Portuguese]	0/10
Ngwenya Mine	July 2023	July 2023	0/10
Tintsaba Crafts	October 2020	October 2020	0/10

To Eat - Restaurants

Restaurant	Most Recent - English	Most Recent - Any Language	# of Mgmt. Responses of Most Recent 10 Reviews
Gil Vicente Portuguese Restaurant	October 2023	December 2023 [Spanish]	0/10
Ramblas Restaurant	March 2024	March 2024	1/10
Luxy garden restaurant	July 2023	July 2023	6/10
Maguga Viewpoint Restaurant	November 2019	November 2019	0/10
Mugg & Bean	February 2022	February 2022	0/10
Malandela's Lifestyle	August 2023	August 2023	7/10
Hippo Haunt Restaurant & Bar	May 2020	February 2024 [Dutch]	0/10
The Waffle Palace Co.	July 2022	July 2022	0/10
Foresters Arms Hotel	August 2022	September 2023 [Dutch]	0/10
The Calabash Continental Restaurant	March 2020	March 2020	0/10

Annex 5 - Keywords by intent

Type of Keyword	Purpose	Who Should Use
Informational	▪ Looking for answers, information, or knowledge about a topic ▪ Early stages of planning a trip or seeking general details about a destination	▪ Destination management organizations (DMOs), tourism boards, and educational sites ▪ Provide rich, informative content that helps users learn about destinations, attractions, culture, and travel tips
Navigational	▪ Searching for a specific website or page ▪ Users already have a destination in mind and use search engines to get there directly	▪ Specific brands, organizations, or attractions with a strong brand presence ▪ Ensure their sites are optimized for navigational queries related to their name or specific offerings
Commercial	▪ Blend of informational and transactional intents, where users are considering a purchase and are looking for information to help them make a decision ▪ Comparing prices, looking for the best deals, or researching the best options for their needs	▪ Comparison sites, review platforms, and content sites offering travel-related services or products ▪ Focus on comparisons, reviews, and detailed product or service information to assist in the decision-making process
Transactional	▪ Ready to buy or complete an action, such as booking a hotel or purchasing tickets for attractions	▪ Travel agencies, booking platforms, and e-commerce sites selling travel-related products or services ▪ Sites should optimize for transactional queries to capture users ready to make a purchase or booking

Annex 6 - Market Segmentation Characteristics

Effective market segmentation has the following characteristics (Moscardo et al., 2001, pp. 31):

Characteristics	Meaning
Homogeneity	People within a segment should be similar to each other and segments should be as different from each other as possible.
Measurable	Segments must be quantifiable in order to allow for targeted marketing strategies
Substantial	Segments are large enough to justify having separate attention
Accessible	Destination should be able to reach/market to this segment
Defensible	Segments must require different marketing approaches
Competitive	Destination must be competitive in offering products or services to this segment
Compatible	Segments must be compatible with destination's existing markets
Durable	Segments must remain relatively stable over period of time




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